EDITURA
MIDAWAY

Maya, Bro & HakunaMatata



MIDA MALENA

MIDA MALENA

Maya, Bro & Hakuna Matata

MIDAWAY
ROMANIA • 2026

MAYA, BRO & HAKUNA MATATA / MIDA MALENA
MIDAWAY Publishing

This book is protected by copyright.
No part of this work may be reproduced, distributed, transmitted, published, translated, adapted, or stored in any form or by any means — electronic, mechanical, photocopying, recording, or otherwise — without the author's prior written permission, except for brief quotations used in reviews, articles, presentations, or critical materials, provided that the source is acknowledged.

Author's Note

This book is a work of fictionalised autobiographical prose inspired by real events experienced by the author. The people, places, events, and experiences on which it is based are real, but have been transformed through memory, selection, compression, and literary stylisation. To protect the privacy of the people involved, some names, characteristics, dialogue, timelines, locations, and identifying details have been changed, obscured, combined, or fictionalised.

This book is not intended as a documentary account, nor does it seek to provide a complete, objective, or verifiable record of the journey. Rather, it transforms experience into a story about freedom, intuition, personal boundaries, unexpected encounters, and the way we look at the world — and the way the world looks back at us. The characters are literary constructions and should not be interpreted as exhaustive portrayals of the real people who inspired them. This book is not intended to defame, disparage, or harm the reputation of any person, community, institution, or location.

Editing, Proofreading & Cover Design: Ciunca Alexandra, Ciunca Adina

Descrierea CIP a Bibliotecii Naţionale a României MIDA MALENA
Maya, Bro & Hakuna Matata / Mida Malena. - Cocorăştii Colţ : Midaway, 2026
ISBN 978-630-95478-9-7 PDF

email: contact@midaway.ro | phone: +40 0740.010.119
Copyright © 2026 Mida Malena. All rights reserved.

Contents

1. Maya 3
2. The Woman Who Wanted Coffee 13
3. Pepper Spray 37
4. I'd Already Been Told 45
5. The Cow on the Red Carpet 53
6. How Are You, Darling? 80
7. See You Tomorrow, Darling 93
8. Cesare = FIE 105
9. Boss Is Sleeping 117
10. The Last Room 124
11. Hakuna Matata 132
12. Hope to Meet U Again 144

The Energy U Carry 155

Dedicated to all the things that didn't go according to plan.

Fortunately.

1

Maya

I'm at the train station, and I still have no idea which way I'm going.

It would be more worrying if I did. That would mean I had a plan, and plans, as far as I've noticed, have a nasty habit of falling out with reality the exact moment you start relying on them. So I've made myself a much simpler – and therefore much more dangerous – promise: I'll take the first train out.

In front of me, the departures board blinks away, full of numbers, letters, and assorted other symbols it insists on calling information. I stare at it with the patience of someone genuinely trying to understand but apparently lacking some of the necessary organs. It stares back with the same impassive blinking, as though the two of us have been caught in a long-standing administrative misunderstanding.

Somewhere inside me, Bro wakes up at his leisure.

BRO: "You always do this."

I don't hear him with my ears. Bro doesn't need ears, signal, or battery life. He's that part of me that shows up whenever the rest of me starts improvising badly, providing commentary from the sidelines with the kind of clarity I'd normally prefer to have *before* buying tickets.

MAYA: "Do what?"

BRO: "Get to a train station and only then decide where you're going."

MAYA: "You're exaggerating."

BRO: "You have a backpack on your back and no destination."

MAYA: "I have a destination."

BRO: "Where?"

I look at the board again. My eyes drift obediently and uselessly from one line to the next, like employees pretending to work.

MAYA: "I'm looking for it."

The woman at the ticket counter smiles at me before I even reach her. Some people smile at you as though they already know you're about to get confused and, in some inexplicable way, have decided to forgive you in advance.

"Where do you want to go?"

"Kochi?"

I say it like a question, not a destination, but she doesn't seem bothered. Maybe destinations here don't need to be stated with quite so much certainty. Maybe it's enough to suggest them to the world and see if it agrees.

"Sixty rupees. How are you paying?"

"UPI. Wait. What time does it leave?"

She looks at the screen, then at me.

"You're lucky. It's running twenty minutes late. Platform one."

Today, luck in India arrives without fanfare. Not through an open door, not as some grand sign, not in the form of a guru dressed in white pointing me in the right direction, but as a delayed train – delayed by exactly the right amount of time to keep up with a decision made on the spot.

The platform is packed, but trains have their own way of making room for everyone, even when there doesn't seem to be any room left. I weave through the crowd with my backpack on and coffee on my mind. I spot a coffee kiosk before I've even worked out whether I have time to stop.

I do. And if I don't, I'll make some.

Bro is quiet. And when Bro is quiet, it usually doesn't mean he approves. It means he's collecting material for later.

When the train pulls in, I climb into the first carriage that looks willing to have me. I don't know if it's the right one. I don't even know if there is such a thing as a *right carriage* in my story. All around me, doors are open, people are getting on, people are getting off, and I, backpack and all, step into a system I still don't entirely understand but which, for now, seems willing to swallow me without asking too many questions.

I even find a seat. Around me are a few girls, two older men, and a child watching the world with the solemn concentration of a ticket inspector. I put my backpack up on the luggage rack, breathe, and for a few minutes I have the distinct impression that I've beaten the system.

This is, obviously, a temporary impression.

About half an hour later, the ticket inspector appears. A woman in a slightly faded uniform takes my ticket, taps something into her device, then looks up at me. She has that particular administrative calm of someone who already knows you're the problem but is still granting you the privilege of finding out for yourself.

"That'll be another ninety rupees. This is the sleeper coach."

I look at her.

"Uh… seriously? So which coach is my ticket for?"

"The last one. Second class."

"Can I go there?"

"Yes."

"Through the train?"

"Yes."

She delivers that last *yes* with the serenity of someone for whom crossing a moving train with a backpack, through packed carriages, is not an event. It's a minor operation the human species figured out long before I came along with my questions.

I get up with dignity – or as much dignity as you can reasonably maintain after discovering that your actual seat is ten carriages away. I pull my backpack down from the luggage rack, sling it over my shoulder, and set off.

One carriage. Then another. And another.

Indian trains aren't meant to be crossed. They're meant to be accepted.

Between carriages, you negotiate with doors, chains, people, bags, feet, vendors, smells, and your own concept of personal space, which evaporates quickly and without compensation.

Ten carriages. Not fewer.

BRO: "Remember when you said you wanted a quiet day today?"

MAYA: "No."

BRO: "Neither do I."

I reach the last door between carriages and discover that I can't go any farther. The last coach exists, just not for me. Between the two of us there isn't a door, but an architectural decision.

So I stay there, between carriages, until the next station.

It's not actually that bad. Air rushes in around the doors, the train moves beneath my feet, and India streams past me in flashes of green, wet, alive. I take out my phone and start filming. If I can't get where I'm supposed to be, I might as well turn it into a scene.

MAYA: "See? I can handle myself."

BRO: "That wasn't the question."

I wait with my backpack pressed against me, feeling as though the train has just given me a reverse upgrade: from the wrong kind of comfort to the right kind of reality.

When the train slows down, I get off. Not because I want to, but because the last coach – the one my ticket is actually for – can only be reached from the outside.

I can see it down there, at the far end of the railway universe: *second class*. The class of the many. The people who don't ask if there's room. They just get on.

Getting in is a struggle. Men are packed together by the entrance, shoulders, elbows, and knees compressed into the same hot patience. I feel their eyes settle on me – not aggressively, not even necessarily with curiosity, but the way you might look at an unexpected object that has appeared in a place where everything else already has its assigned position.

And now I have to squeeze past them, heavy backpack and all, because there is no other way in.

Inside, the air hangs still and thick, layered with sweat, hot metal, damp clothes, heated plastic, and the smell of food unpacked from containers. It isn't one smell. It's several lives stacked on top of one another.

Every body guards its few inches of space. Every bag seems to have legal rights. Every face says the same thing: there's room for one more, but don't ask how.

BRO: "This is what your ticket was for?"

MAYA: "Officially, yes."

BRO: "Unofficially?"

MAYA: "Unofficially, I think India is testing me."

I push forward with my backpack in front of me, then sideways, then almost on top of someone, trying not to hit knees, heads, bottles, children, or whatever remains of my personal dignity.

A man appears in the aisle carrying a blue barrel, probably filled with ice and drinks. I don't know exactly what he's selling, and it doesn't matter. At that moment, to me, he is the man who can part the carriage.

People move for him.

I fall in behind.

He cuts a path through the carriage; I stay in his wake. Barrels, backpacks, and survival instincts, under certain circumstances, command roughly the same authority. Nobody makes room for a woman who can barely fit through with her backpack, but everybody makes room for a man selling something cold.

About halfway down the carriage, I spot an empty space on the luggage rack above.

Small. Improbable. Almost poetic.

I ask the man with the barrel to help me. He lifts my backpack as though it were a sleeping animal, pushes it up onto the rack, and suddenly my body is no longer carrying my entire biography.

I stay standing between seats and people. There isn't much room, but the windows are wide open, which already feels like luxury.

Five minutes pass. Maybe less. Time in second class isn't measured by a clock. It's measured by how close someone's elbow is to your ribs, by how many stops your body can endure before it stops asking where it's going, and by how many pairs of eyes look you up and down before finally deciding to leave you alone.

A man seated next to me lightly touches my arm and gestures toward his seat.

"I'm getting off at the next stop. You sit here."

I look at him. Then at the seat.

I smile.

BRO: "Don't tell me you got lucky again."

MAYA: "I won't."

BRO: "But you did."

MAYA: "A little."

BRO: "Maya."

MAYA: "Fine. Very."

When the train stops again, the man gets off, and I take his seat with the silent gratitude of someone who has just been handed a palace with a plastic backrest.

I stay there all the way to Kochi, knees tucked in, backpack above my head. Every now and then the train stops. More people get on, others get off. A hand passes in front of me carrying a bag. A child falls asleep with his cheek pressed against his mother's arm. Someone opens up their food. Someone else stares out the window as though the answer to every question might be somewhere out there.

I have no answers. I have a seat in second class, an open window somewhere nearby, and a few hours in which I don't have to decide anything. For now, that's enough.

I get off the train around noon with the vague feeling that I've arrived somewhere, even though my body is still moving to the rhythm of the tracks. The station recedes behind me – all metal, footsteps, voices, and announcements I can't understand – packed with people who seem to know exactly where they're going, which, at this point, strikes me as mildly suspicious.

I know exactly one thing: Fort Kochi.

A small patch on the map.

Maybe.

I remember Bastian Homestay, a place I'd seen online: 1,050 rupees a night. The price seemed reasonable, the place looked clean and almost homely – exactly the kind of illusion a person needs after crossing ten carriages just to reach the class she actually paid for.

BRO: "Did you book it?"

MAYA: "No."

BRO: "Of course not."

MAYA: "I want to see the room first."

BRO: "Big words from someone who didn't know which carriage she belonged in an hour ago."

I roll my eyes internally, because externally I need all available energy just to keep walking in a straight line.

The metro is a few hundred metres from the station. I walk there with my backpack on and the stride of someone who hasn't admitted she's tired yet but has already entered negotiations with the fatigue.

At every crossing, the city seems to size me up: cars, scooters, horns, the smell of warm rain rising from the asphalt, and the occasional dog sprawled with imperial indifference in a spot where I wouldn't dare stand for three seconds.

Taxi drivers ask where I'm going with their eyes.

I keep walking.

I take the metro for two stops. Twenty rupees for a few minutes of air-conditioning and order. The air-conditioning isn't comfort. It's a brief intermission from the reality of the day.

I get off and, for a few seconds, become convinced that things are finally settling into a straight line – which is the first sign that I'm about to misunderstand everything.

I still have a fair bit of the city to cover on foot. Almost two kilometres, according to the map, in its optimistic little voice and complete absence of a backpack.

I set off slowly. Not that I have much choice. The weight pulls at my shoulders, my T-shirt sticks to my back, and within minutes I can feel every single thing inside my backpack as a bad decision made in another lifetime.

I stop once.

Then again.

Not because I can't go on, obviously. I'm admiring the city.

BRO: "You're admiring the kerb."

MAYA: "It's an interesting kerb."

A few drops start to fall. Not real rain, just enough for the sky to remind me that it, too, is participating in the journey.

I take shelter under the edge of a roof beside a tiny shop with narrow shelves and brightly coloured packets hanging by the entrance like flags of everyday survival. The smell of wet dust, hot oil, and overripe fruit mingles in the air.

The city doesn't stop for the rain. It just sweats differently.

Then I reach the jetty, where the boats leave from.

Only then do I realise that Fort Kochi isn't just a neighbourhood you walk into. There is water between me and it. The map, naturally, had not considered this detail dramatic enough to mention. On the screen, everything had looked like a simple line, a reasonable distance, the kind of route a woman with a backpack could manage without beginning to renegotiate her entire life.

I have to get on a boat, pay another forty rupees, and accept that Bastian Homestay, looking so innocent on the map, already requires a combination of transport methods.

The backwaters open up in front of me, wide, murky, alive. There is nothing remarkable about the boat, which is exactly why I like it. Around me are a few students, locals who look as though they've made this crossing a thousand times, a man staring at his phone with absolute concentration, and a woman with her hair pulled tightly back, holding a bag of vegetables against her chest like a well-behaved child.

I sit with my backpack beside me and my eyes on the water. Fort Kochi slowly draws closer: palm trees, old walls, low buildings, and the air of a place that has seen too many ships come and go to remain entirely innocent.

There is something colonial and tired about it, beautiful and slightly weathered, like an old photograph someone forgot in the sun.

BRO: "So you picked the place without knowing you had to cross the water."

MAYA: "I picked it intuitively."

BRO: "Geography weeps."

I get off the boat and check the map. I still have about a kilometre to walk to the homestay.

I haven't booked anything. I want to see the room first, get a feel for the place, find out whether I'll be greeted by a heavy smell or by that particular kind of quiet in which a person can sleep without regretting every decision she has ever made.

And, more importantly, I want coffee.

Actually, by this point, coffee is no longer something I want. It is the only form of navigation I am still willing to accept.

I find a café on the map. Four minutes away.

Four minutes.

A human distance – a small, round promise with milk foam on top.

I cross the jetty and walk out of the little harbour with renewed determination.

BRO: “Coffee?”

MAYA: “Any minute now.”

BRO: “This is serious.”

2

The Woman Who Wanted Coffee

At the port exit, the air changes.

Not much. Just enough for me to realise I've stepped into a place where everyone seems to know something I don't yet.

"Taxi, madam?"

"Tuk-tuk?"

"Where are you going?"

"Island tour?"

"I show you the best places."

They come at me from every direction, their voices overlapping into the local chorus of arrivals. Every port on the planet has its own ritual: men waiting by the exit, watching the luggage, the hesitation, the phones open on Google Maps.

A person with a backpack is never just a person with a backpack.

They're an economic opportunity.

I smile, shake my head, say '*no, thank you*' a few times, and keep walking with the dignity of a woman who knows exactly where she's going.

Which is to a coffee four minutes away.

BRO: "Ambitious itinerary."

MAYA: "Don't ruin this for me."

"Madam, tuk-tuk? Very good tour. Chinese fishing nets, Dutch Palace, synagogue, spice market..."

The tourist list begins, inevitably, delivered with the tired precision of a man who has said the same words a thousand times and still hopes that this time, someone will stop.

Attractions. Landmarks. History.

'Very famous.' 'Very old.' 'Very nice.'

Everything is very something.

"No, no. I'm walking."

I keep going, phone in hand, coffee pinned on the map.

But one of them doesn't leave.

He walks alongside me, sometimes half a step behind, sometimes half a step ahead, in a perfectly choreographed performance of polite persistence. He's stocky, quick, bright-eyed, with a colourful laminated folder in his hand, worn at the corners and full of photographs of places every tourist is apparently required to see before being allowed to leave Fort Kochi.

"Madam, I take you."

"No, I'm walking."

"Where are you going?"

He glances at my phone.

"Ah. Coffee. I take you for coffee."

I stop and laugh.

"It's four minutes away."

He doesn't laugh.

To him, four minutes is plenty of time for a negotiation, a strategy, and, who knows, possibly an entire day.

"No problem. I take you. But first, one shop."

"I don't want to go shopping."

"No shopping. Just looking."

'*Just looking*' is an institution.

It never means just looking.

It means going inside, being seated in a chair, being offered tea, and having silks, gemstones, perfumes, carved wood, shawls, carpets, and, eventually, your own guilt laid out in front of you.

"I'm not buying anything."

"You don't have to buy. I get money."

I look at him.

"What do you mean?"

He starts explaining.

Fast. Very fast. Too fast.

I catch words, lose sentences, cling to meaning the way I clung to the handrails on the train: shop, customer, tuk-tuk, two hundred rupees, you don't buy, no problem, voucher, I get money.

"So I go into the shop…"

"Yes."

"I don't buy anything."

"No need."

"You get money."

"Yes, madam. Two hundred rupees."

"Because I walked in?"

"Yes."

"And then we go for coffee?"

"Yes. Good coffee."

He looks at me with such complete sincerity that, for a few seconds, the whole arrangement starts to resemble a public service.

BRO: "I don't like it when I understand something and still don't like it."

MAYA: "Neither do I."

"No customers today, madam," he says, more quietly now. "No business. You go inside, I get two hundred. You don't buy. Good for me. Good for you. Then coffee."

And that is where something gives way in my defensive logic.

Not completely. Just enough for a tuk-tuk to fit through the crack.

Maybe because I'm tired and hungry and want that coffee with the urgency of a medical intervention. Or maybe because he has that colourful folder in his hand and the small desperation of someone trying to turn an empty day into an acceptable one.

"Fine," I say. "But one shop. Then coffee."

His face lights up instantly.

"Yes, madam! One shop. Then coffee. You wait here. I bring tuk-tuk."

He puts the folder in my hands.

He doesn't just hand it to me. He entrusts it to me – as though it were a relay baton, a child, or physical proof that the two of us have just entered into an agreement neither of us has fully defined.

Then he disappears.

I'm left standing at the port exit with my backpack on, my phone in one hand, and a stranger's colourful folder in the other, as though I've just been temporarily hired by a tour agency without signing anything.

BRO: "Nice."

MAYA: "What?"

BRO: "You wanted coffee. You got responsibilities."

I start laughing to myself. Not loudly, just enough for me to hear it. I've just said yes to a man whose plan I don't fully understand, in a city I arrived in less than an hour ago, all for a coffee that was four minutes away and is somehow becoming increasingly difficult to reach.

The tuk-tuk appears with a small, insolent rattle, like a motorised insect. The man waves at me with his whole arm, delighted.

"Come, madam!"

"What's your name?"

"Safi."

"I'm Maya."

"Maya madam."

"Just Maya."

"Yes, Maya madam."

I climb in. My backpack bangs against the side, I squeeze myself in beside it, and the tuk-tuk jolts off through Fort Kochi, away from my café – the one that was supposed to be four minutes away.

Only then do I begin to understand the arrangement.

Safi takes tourists to certain shops. The shops give him a voucher, proof that he has successfully delivered a foreign body through their doors, and then he gets his commission. Two hundred rupees for a customer brought in by tuk-tuk. Four hundred for one brought by car.

It doesn't matter whether the tourist buys anything. What matters is that they go inside, look around, and are exposed to the beauty.

The rest is commercial hope.

The first shop doesn't look like a shop. It looks like a museum that, for reasons open to question, accepts credit cards.

I walk in, backpack and all, slightly sweaty, slightly confused, still dreaming about coffee. An impeccably dressed man smiles at me from behind a wall of professional composure.

"Welcome, madam. Please, come in."

It's cool inside. Or maybe there's just a lot of shade. After the street, any amount of shade feels like a form of luxury. I leave my backpack on a chair and immediately feel twenty kilos more elegant.

All around me unfolds a world of objects that seem to have waited hundreds of years for the sole purpose of demonstrating that I can't afford any of them: antiques, silks, carved figurines, wooden boxes with tiny locks, stones that catch the light and hold it captive, perfumes in little bottles, soft shawls, carpets hanging from the walls, rolled up, spread out, all of them promising homes, floors, and lives I do not have.

I realise very quickly that everything here is partly a museum. Even the shops seem designed for people who walk in with their hands clasped behind their backs and walk out with mortgages.

The salesman shows me a silk scarf.

"Pure silk, madam. Very good quality."

He touches it lightly, unfurls it into the air, and the fabric spills across the light like coloured water.

It's beautiful.

Of course it's beautiful.

That's the trouble with beautiful things: it isn't their fault they don't fit into your life.

"How much is it?"

"Four thousand rupees."

I smile with all the aristocracy I can muster.

"It's very beautiful."

In the universal language of the broke tourist, *it's very beautiful* means *no*.

The salesman keeps trying. He shows me another one. Then another. Colours, textures, promises.

For a few minutes, I play the part of a woman who could buy anything in the shop but simply hasn't made up her mind yet for aesthetic reasons rather than financial ones.

It's a pleasant role. Brief, but pleasant.

Then I see the carpet.

I don't know how to describe it without sounding ridiculous. It's the kind of carpet that requires more than money. It requires a destiny. A large house. A quiet living room. Tall windows. A life in which nobody ever walks inside wearing shoes, not even by accident.

I stand in front of it and, for a second, imagine the house.

Not my house, because my entire house is currently sitting inside a backpack on a chair.

A possible house. One belonging to a version of me who knows how to buy carpets without mentally checking the exchange rate first.

"Very special, madam," the salesman says.

"Yes. I can see that."

"Handmade."

Of course it's handmade.

No ten-thousand-euro carpet should be allowed to be anything else.

"How much?"

He tells me the price.

I laugh a little. Elegantly. I don't want to offend the carpet.

"When I buy a house, I'll come back for it."

The salesman smiles.

"I give you very good discount."

"Perfect. But let's make sure the house costs a little more than the carpet, okay?"

I'm not sure he gets the joke, but he keeps smiling, which, in retail, is a form of patience.

I walk out with no scarf, no stones, no perfume, no carpet. Just my eyes full of everything.

Safi is waiting for me outside.

He doesn't ask whether I bought anything. I like that about him. He doesn't look like a man who'd made a serious investment in me. He just has the satisfaction of someone who has already got what he needed.

He holds up the little voucher between two fingers.

"Two hundred rupees, Maya madam!"

He's happy.

Purely, genuinely happy.

As though I haven't just refused to buy a scarf, but the two of us have won a match together.

BRO: "Congratulations. You went shopping without shopping."

MAYA: "And made money without buying anything."

BRO: "Minimalist capitalism."

Safi heads towards the tuk-tuk with the energy of a man whose day has just got back on its feet.

"One more shop? Then coffee. Now we have money for coffee."

I look at him, then at the street, and think about my coffee, which is drifting farther and farther away like a promise with flexible opening hours.

And then I laugh.

"Come on, Safi. One more."

You can't imagine how happy he is.

Or maybe you can, if you've ever seen someone accidentally handed exactly the little piece of luck they needed not to go home with an empty day.

The tuk-tuk sets off again.

I sit in the back with my backpack beside me, my hair sticking to the back of my neck, the colourful folder on my knees, and the distinct feeling that I've somehow joined a tour no travel agency has ever invented: the tour of sublime objects you do not buy.

Guide: Safi.

Price: zero rupees for me.

Profit: two hundred rupees per stop for him.

Coffee: still uncertain.

The day, which began with a delayed train and was supposed to continue with a simple cup of coffee, has just changed species entirely.

At the second shop, Safi pulls the tuk-tuk up outside and turns to me with a new kind of authority, the authority of a man who feels our relationship has already survived its first commercial test.

"Leave your bag here. Don't carry it. I won't run away."

By now, he has given me his WhatsApp number, which, by the logic of the day, already seems like a sufficient social contract.

"I have your number, Safi. I'm not worried you'll run away."

He laughs, delighted, as though I've just paid him a serious compliment.

"Good, Maya madam. Go. Just looking."

I go in without my backpack and immediately feel lighter, almost fraudulent, as though what I've left outside isn't a piece of luggage but the evidence of my real life.

Inside, another salesman greets me. Thinner than the first, smoother in his movements, with a smile already prepared for every possible form of refusal.

"Please, madam. Tea?"

"No, thank you."

"Earrings?"

"No, thank you."

"Silk scarf?"

"No, thank you."

"Just see."

Just see returns, naturally, as the standard formula of every shop you enter as a free human being and leave as a survivor of commercial politeness.

He shows me earrings, brings out scarves, opens drawers, boxes, little pouches – tiny worlds of metal, stone, and silk.

Every object comes with a story. Every story comes with a price. Every price comes with a pause in which I'm apparently supposed to feel guilty.

I smile, admire, touch, and say *beautiful* with almost diplomatic delicacy, but I hold my ground.

In the end, I thank him for his kindness with the solemnity of a woman who has just crossed a battlefield of silk and silver without losing a single rupee.

I step back out onto the street, and Safi is waiting beside the tuk-tuk, his face lit up.

He has the voucher in his hand.

"Two hundred!"

He holds it up slightly, like good news.

And it is good news.

BRO: "Careful. You're starting to root for the scheme."

MAYA: "I'm not rooting for the scheme."

BRO: "You're rooting for its accountant."

"Coffee now?" I ask.

"Yes, yes. Coffee."

Naturally, we do not go for coffee.

We go to a little local eatery instead.

It has absolutely nothing in common with the café I had imagined – the one four minutes away on foot, with cappuccino, maybe a small

table, maybe a lazy fan, maybe a moment of nicely frothed Western peace.

The place Safi chooses is simple, lively, crowded, with a counter open to the street, people passing right beside us, and the smell of boiled milk, hot oil, dough, and spices in the air. The kind of place where you stand, drink something hot, nobody asks how you're feeling, and then you move on.

Safi orders two milky cardamom chais.

"My favourite," he says.

And the way he says it turns the chai into a personal recommendation rather than a drink.

It arrives hot, sweet, thick, the milk rounding off every edge and the cardamom rising with the steam. I hold it between my palms and, for a few seconds, forget about coffee. This worries me. Until now, coffee has been the only coherent plan I've had all day.

Safi gets two little chicken tarts as well, then a piece of fried banana.

"This is for you."

"We'll share it."

"No. For you."

"Safi."

"Okay. Half-half."

The banana is warm, oily, sweet, with a slightly crisp edge.

It isn't dessert and it isn't quite food. It's a kind of fried peace.

Safi pays.

I try to protest, but he dismisses me with one short, decisive gesture. He has just made four hundred rupees thanks to a woman who bought absolutely nothing. By the mathematics of the day, he owes me at least a chai.

And then, naturally, we go to another shop.

Because if the man makes money from me walking into beautiful places and coming out empty-handed, who am I to stand in the way of the local economy?

The next stop is a spice shop. Safi simply calls it the *spices store*.

To get there, we climb through an old house, up a narrow flight of tired wooden stairs that creak beneath every step as though they have opinions about the weight of tourists.

Upstairs, the room suddenly opens out, filled with a mixture of smells so dense I can almost see it. Cardamom, cinnamon, pepper, cloves, wood, incense, dust, something sweet, something bitter, something that goes straight into your memory without asking permission.

Two girls and a man stand among shelves, bags, jars, boxes, and brightly coloured packets. The whole place seems to be made of scent and old wood.

That's where I see the incense sticks.

I approach them with the caution of a woman who has already survived four-thousand-rupee scarves. I tell myself there's no way a little packet of incense sticks can be dangerous. They're thin, light, almost innocent.

I smell one. Then another. Then another.

I choose some blue ones without being entirely sure what they smell like, because after three samples my nose gives up on discernment and starts approving everything.

I take them to the counter.

"Four hundred and eighty rupees."

I look at the salesman.

"For these?"

He smiles.

I look at the packet again. Twenty thin incense sticks, probably not even a hundred grams, one small fragrant bundle that, at that price, ought to perfume my past, my future, and every room I will ever sleep in.

"No, thank you."

I leave them at the counter with cold dignity.

I go back downstairs.

Safi is waiting for me at the bottom.

This time, there is no voucher held triumphantly in the air.

"This one gives no money," he says.

"Nothing?"

"Nothing."

I look back at the old house, the wooden stairs, the scent still lingering on my fingers.

"Good luck to them."

BRO: "You just turned down luxury incense."

MAYA: "Those incense sticks had master's degrees."

I take a few photos outside, and Safi instantly recovers his enthusiasm.

"One more?"

By now, I like him.

Not just the scheme, not just the ride, but the way the day keeps carrying itself forward without asking whether I approve of this new version of it.

I like that I still haven't made it to the homestay. That I still haven't had my coffee. That I'm riding around in a tuk-tuk with a man who has somehow turned me into a walking economic resource and that, strangely, I don't feel used. I feel included in his hustle.

At the next shop, the owner is the kind of salesman who doesn't just sell objects. He sells demonstrations.

He has the slow, confident gestures of someone who knows that beauty has to be staged before it can be refused.

He shows me carpets.

Not one. Not two. Seven.

He carefully unrolls them across the floor, spreads them out, smooths them down, lets them catch the light. Some have geometric patterns, others flowers, others colours that seem perfectly calm at first and then, when you look more closely, begin to work against you.

"Special cut, madam," he says. "Different pile. You will see."

He chooses one carpet and lays it out in the middle of the room. Then he looks at me very seriously.

"Close your eyes."

"Close my eyes?"

"Yes. Close your eyes. Give me your hand."

I give him my hand.

BRO: "Excellent. In a carpet shop. With a stranger."

MAYA: "It's for art."

The man slowly leads me around the carpet. I walk with my eyes closed, slightly embarrassed, slightly amused, trying not to put a foot wrong, trip over anything, or turn the demonstration into an international incident involving silk and insurance.

"Now open."

I open my eyes.

The carpet is a different colour.

Not an entirely different colour, not some cheap fairground trick, but that subtle, impossible shift that makes you step closer.

From one side it looks darker. From another, warmer. From another, almost luminous. The way the pile is cut changes how it catches the light, and the pattern shifts as I move.

For a moment, I forget that I'm not supposed to buy anything.

That's the real danger. Not the price. Not the persistence. The moment an object shows you that it knows how to be more than an object.

The owner explains the technique: how the pile is cut, how the light falls across it, how the exact same weave can look completely different simply because you've moved a few steps.

It is annoyingly convincing.

Then he tries to sell me a meditation mat.

I come straight back down to earth.

"Meditation mat, madam. Very good. Small. Easy to carry."

He unfolds it in front of me.

It's beautiful, of course. Everything is beautiful in these shops. Even the impossible comes embroidered.

"You travel. Good for you. Meditation."

Of course.

That's what my backpack has been missing: a meditation mat.

Never mind that I have three T-shirts, seven dresses, a towel, two shirts, cables, more cosmetics than I can count, a travelling pharmacy, a laptop, an epilator, a notebook, chargers, and the permanent feeling that I've packed too much.

No.

The real problem is the absence of a little mat on which I can sit perfectly still while the rest of my luggage judges me.

"I don't have room."

"Look. It folds."

And he folds it.

About the size of a towel.

I have to give him credit: the man knows exactly where to strike at the weakest point in my excuse.

BRO: "There goes the space argument."

MAYA: "I still have the money argument."

BRO: "A classic."

I thank him.

I tell him it's very beautiful. I tell him maybe next time. I'm beginning to use *next time* as an elegant way of leaving a room without hurting the objects' feelings.

Outside, Safi gets his voucher and instantly acquires the expression of a man for whom art has just delivered a return on investment.

"One more, Maya madam?"

At the next shop, something new happens: the salesman figures me out almost immediately. He has a trained eye.

Within the first two minutes, he sizes me up from my little braid all the way down to my flip-flops, then moves on to the way I touch things: with admiration, but no intention.

He understands that I'm not here to buy anything. I'm here to pass through beauty the way you pass through a museum.

And that's when he relaxes. He stops trying to sell me things.

We start talking instead.

"Where are you from?"

"Romania."

"You travel alone?"

"Yes."

"What do you do?"

"I write."

Something shifts.

Until then, I was a tourist. After *I write*, I become a case.

I show him my books on Amazon. He takes out his phone, looks them up, zooms in on the covers, reads my name, raises his eyebrows. His fascination is genuine, and I can feel my role changing yet again.

I'm no longer the woman who isn't buying anything because there's no room in her backpack. I'm the writer exploring the beauty of the city. I immediately notice that this version works much better.

I don't have room in my backpack is a practical excuse.

I'm a writer travelling the world is practically an aristocratic profession.

BRO: "You've rebranded poverty."

MAYA: "It's called storytelling."

He gives me his business card. He tells me he has Amazon Prime and that he'll read my books. I half believe him, which, when travelling, is already a generous form of trust.

By the end of the tour, I have three business cards in my pocket and no longer know exactly which man belongs to which shop. Cottage Something. Art Emporium. Craft India. Gilded, promising

names, all jumbled together in my head with silk, carved wood, spices, sweet tea, and Safi's voice returning again and again, tireless:

"One more, Maya madam?"

Then he takes me somewhere to take pictures.

That's how he puts it.

"Good place. Photos."

We end up on a street full of people, shops, brightly coloured walls, old doors, plants spilling over fences, motorcycles parked crookedly, cables, hand-painted signs, patches of shade, the occasional dog, a woman walking past with a shopping bag, a man leaning against a doorway as though the place had belonged to him since before any of the empires arrived.

Safi turns out to be an amateur photographer.

I'm not joking. He takes my phone with the seriousness of an artist who has finally been given an international subject.

He motions for me to stand by a wall. Then by a gate. Then to walk. Then turn around. Then laugh.

"Natural, Maya madam. Natural."

I laugh precisely because nothing about this is natural anymore.

I'm in Fort Kochi, in the middle of an impromptu photo shoot with a tuk-tuk driver who has just made money by taking me to shops I walked out of empty-handed. And yet, in the photos, I look exactly where I'm supposed to be.

We go to one more shop.

There, another man tries to sell me earrings. By now, I'm trained. I smile, I look, I admire, I don't buy. I show him my Instagram, show him my books, tell him I'm travelling, that I write, that I'm exploring the city, that the beauty of these places matters, that my luggage is small.

And once again, I notice the atmosphere shift when I say it.

I don't have room is a modest excuse. Easy to argue with.

I write about places opens a different door.

My refusal no longer feels like a refusal. It feels like a method. I'm no longer just a tourist who doesn't buy anything. I'm a woman collecting impressions, a customer of the world rather than the shop.

BRO: "You found the loophole."

MAYA: "Literature saves the budget."

Evening is still a long way off, but the day has already expanded far beyond its original shape.

I had set out for coffee. That was all.

Coffee, a room, maybe a shower, maybe two honest hours of sleep.

Instead, I'm in a tuk-tuk buzzing through Fort Kochi with a heavy backpack, pockets full of business cards, a phone full of photos, the taste of chai and fried banana still in my mouth, the smell of spices in my hair, and a happy driver beside me who has made some money without me buying a single thing.

Safi gets vouchers.

I get Fort Kochi from the inside.

Fair deal.

We also go to a perfume factory. That's what Safi calls it: *factory*.

In reality, it's yet another place where commerce dresses itself up as a museum and every object seems to have a longer story than my bank history.

Here, Safi gets only one hundred and fifty rupees.

He shrugs, but doesn't seem disappointed.

"Still good," he says.

In this day's economy, every voucher is a small victory.

Inside, a young woman holds out one tiny bottle of perfume after another. She doesn't test them on paper, as any reasonable person might. She tests them directly on me. Two on one arm. Two on the other. She touches each scent to my skin with precise little movements, then lifts my wrists towards my nose as though introducing me, one by one, to possible versions of my own personality.

One perfume is sweet and heavy. Another is green. Another smells of wood, leather, and a house where no poor person has ever lived.

By the fourth one, I no longer know exactly what I'm smelling. My nose is confused. The perfumes blend into one another, then into the dust from the street, the sweat, the fried bananas, the cardamom from the chai, the silk I touched in the previous shops.

Today, I'm no longer a person.

I'm a sensory inventory.

The woman also shows me an enormous incense stick, displayed like a trophy.

"Guinness Book," she says.

"This one?"

"Yes. Very long. Burns twenty-four hours."

I look at it with the kind of respect you have for something completely useless and yet undeniably impressive.

An incense stick that burns for twenty-four hours. An entire day of scented smoke. An entire day in which someone has to keep believing in the smell right to the very end.

"The small ones burn for one hour," she adds.

Of course.

Even smoke has a hierarchy.

In the same shop, she shows me the largest perfume bottle as well, another local record. Impressive. I don't need it. But impressive.

Naturally, we set off for another shop.

Here, more fabrics are waiting for me, more rarities, more wonders folded, polished, carved, perfumed, buffed, and displayed under carefully placed lights: satin, cashmere, lotus silk. Fabrics I'm told are one-of-a-kind, that no two pieces are ever exactly alike, which naturally makes them even harder to refuse without at least a small gesture of respect.

Then I see something made of wood and metal – tall, strange, pyramid-shaped – that can be used as a bookcase.

And immediately, I need it.

Not now. Not here. Not in this backpack version of my life.

But I definitely need it.

For that big house I've apparently been furnishing in my head ever since the first carpet.

The house with a living room worthy of the ten-thousand-euro carpet. The house with tall windows, where I'll put the pyramid bookcase, the sublime scarves, the floaty dresses, the little bottles of perfume, the carpet nobody will ever be allowed to step on with their shoes on, and probably a twenty-four-hour incense stick, just so the neighbours know I've made it in life.

BRO: "Where is this house?"

MAYA: "In development."

BRO: "Property or psychological?"

MAYA: "Both."

I walk out empty-handed again.

I'm getting very good at this: I enter expensive places, admire the heritage, talk to people, vaguely promise to come back, and leave without buying anything, carrying myself like a woman with options rather than limitations.

It is, quite possibly, the most elegant form of mobile bankruptcy.

BRO: "Finally, a moment of clarity."

MAYA: "Don't ruin it."

Once the shop portion of the day seems to have run its course, Safi decides it's time to find me somewhere to stay.

He turns towards me with the seriousness of a man who has wrapped up the cultural portion of the programme and is finally moving on to logistics.

"Now room, Maya madam."

Of course.

Coffee can wait.

He immediately slips into the role of a man who knows someone. Everyone knows someone. It is one of the most reliable forms of

infrastructure around here, considerably more reliable than the pavements.

He makes a call, talks rapidly, nods a few times, then explains:

"First you see. If you don't like, I take you Bastian."

Bastian Homestay, my original destination on the map, still exists somewhere in the parallel version of the day where I walked out of the port, refused the tuk-tuk, had my coffee, and went straight to my accommodation like a person with a linear life.

But I no longer live in that version. I'm in a tuk-tuk with Safi, driving through Fort Kochi.

The woman he speaks to on the phone sends her father to show us the first place.

There are two rooms on the ground floor. The moment I walk in, the smell hits me.

Mould.

Not a little tropical dampness. Not that vague smell of a room that's been shut for too long. Mould with a personality. Settled into the walls. The kind of mould that, if I stay for three nights, will probably ask me to split the rent.

I look at the walls, the floor, the air that seems not to have moved since the last serious monsoon.

"No, Safi."

I don't even need to explain much.

Safi can smell it too.

"Not good?"

"Not good."

"Okay. Another one."

That's what I like about him.

No performance. No trying to convince me. No telling me it's *very nice* when it very clearly isn't. He accepts reality the way he accepts a bend in the road and turns the tuk-tuk around.

The second place is called Joseph's House.

The name already helps. There's something simple and human about it, as though, after the mould, someone decided to send me a responsible supporting character.

There are two rooms available: one for 1,000 rupees, the other for 1,200. I take the first one, because by this point I've already seen enough objects that cost as much as an imaginary house.

The room isn't luxurious, but it's clean. It has a bed, acceptable walls, the possibility of quietness. Today, I'm not looking for perfection. Just somewhere my backpack can come off my shoulders without anyone crying.

Then comes a minor adventure with the payment. Naturally. The QR code doesn't work because it's linked to a personal account. Digital payments, it turns out, occasionally require an extended family.

He calls his son, who sends me another code. Things are checked. We wait. I stand there with my phone in my hand and the patience of a woman who has already learned that systems do work, just not necessarily in the order you'd prefer.

Eventually, the payment goes through. Three thousand rupees for a room with a balcony, a key, and three days in Fort Kochi.

BRO: "Have you noticed you went out for coffee and somehow ended up booking three nights?"

MAYA: "Progress."

BRO: "Is that what we're calling it now?"

But the day still isn't over.

I'm hungry. Not the kind of hungry you can solve with *I'll wait a little longer*. The kind of hunger that has travelled with me through trains, cities, water, shops, perfumes, mouldy rooms, and financial explanations.

"Pizza?" I ask.

Safi agrees immediately.

Apparently, there are three pizzerias in Fort Kochi.

We pass the first one. I only glimpse it as a glowing promise.

We stop briefly at the second. It's beautiful, green, with a garden, but rather expensive. Too expensive for two people who have just built an entire economy out of two-hundred-rupee commissions and elegant refusals.

The third one has a tree growing through the middle of the building. I don't mean metaphorically. It isn't decorative. It's an actual tree, growing straight through the restaurant, left exactly where it was and incorporated into the architecture like an elderly member of the family. Around it: tables, chairs, lights, people. As though someone had decided to build a pizzeria and the tree had said, *Fine. But I'm staying.*

The place is wonderful.

There's even a scooter there for photos, because apparently nothing is truly complete until you can pose with it.

We sit down.

We order a pizza and two lemonades. We share the pizza, and this time I pay: 672 rupees. That was the deal. We could go eat together if I paid. And that seems fair to me.

Yes, Safi made money with me, but it was his money. His work. His hustle. His network of shops, phone calls, smiles, persistence, rides, and waiting.

I wasn't the victim of the scheme. I was its privileged participant.

BRO: "You're romanticising the hustle."

MAYA: "No. I'm adding nuance."

BRO: "Dangerous word."

We eat the pizza slowly, and Safi starts telling me about his life.

His father died when he and his sister were young. He now lives with his mother and sister. He tells me all this simply, without asking me to be sad about it.

Later, I ask if he's married.

"No. Weddings are expensive in India."

I laugh.

So does he.

For a few minutes, the man who has spent the whole day driving me through perfumes, visits, business deals, and imaginary houses sits across from me and isn't trying to sell me anything. Not even a better version of himself.

After we eat, he takes me back to Joseph's House and leaves. At last, the day seems willing to let me go.

The tuk-tuk buzzes away with the sound of an industrious insect, and I'm left standing on the pavement, for the first time in hours, without his voice, without a map, without a shop, without someone trying to show me something.

Beside the building, I spot a gelato shop. It's small, bright, almost indecently quiet after everything I've been through.

I go in and get myself an ice cream. I sit alone at a little table, spoon in hand, and feel as though silence tastes cold.

Outside, Fort Kochi carries on without me. People pass by. Scooters. Voices. Lights.

Inside, I eat slowly, as though the ice cream were the full stop at the end of a very long sentence.

Eventually, I make it back to my room and get into the shower. The water washes away the dust, the sweat, the smell of the train, the city, the shops, the spices, and all those perfumes layered on top of one another.

My backpack sits in a corner, heavy and silent, as though it too has spent the whole day running around shops and has now fallen asleep from exhaustion.

I plug in my phone, post a few photos, and write about the day that began without a destination and ended with three nights paid for in a place called Joseph's House. Some days can't be kept in memory alone. If you don't write them down, they get their revenge by turning into bad legends, told too quickly.

That morning, I hadn't known exactly where I was going.

By evening, I had arrived at Joseph's House by a route no reasonable map would ever have suggested.

With Safi, I did something I'd never done before.

I played the sophisticated lady.

The lady who walks into museum-like shops, admires ten-thousand-euro carpets, closes her eyes in front of a stranger for a textile demonstration, turns down a foldable meditation mat, and discusses pyramid bookcases, perfumes, books, travel, and imaginary houses. The lady who buys nothing but somehow leaves a trace. Or at least a voucher for Safi.

BRO: "Let's not get carried away with the trace."

MAYA: "Fine. A fiscal trace."

By the end of the evening, the inventory looks like this: a room at Joseph's House, a key, three business cards, photos taken by Safi, perfume still lingering on my wrists, the taste of chai in my mouth, a fully furnished imaginary house, a pizza shared beneath a tree that had refused to leave the restaurant, and a coffee that, technically speaking, still hadn't happened.

The story of today is simple:

I went out for coffee and got an entire movie instead.

3

Pepper Spray

Two days later, I'm back at the train station.

After Fort Kochi, I could have learned something about planning. Naturally, I haven't.

I have a ninety-five-rupee ticket to Mangalore, a coffee that doesn't taste like coffee, a small bottle of coconut water, and the same provisional relationship with direction.

The station officers tell me something about an upgrade, overcrowding, another class, more comfort. I listen politely and do nothing. My ticket, as usual, is for the lowest class: among people, among luggage, among reality.

BRO: "You could choose comfort."

MAYA: "I could."

BRO: "But?"

MAYA: "I'm afraid I might miss the material."

The train arrives, and the carriage fills with the speed of a well-organised panic. People get on before the others have got off, luggage goes wherever it can, bodies adjust, nobody asks whether there's any room left.

In second class, space doesn't exist. It gets invented.

I make my way forward with difficulty, backpack on, when a young man in a white T-shirt coming from the opposite direction gestures with his eyes: first at me, then at the backpack, then up towards the luggage rack.

I understand. I hand him the backpack, and he lifts it easily and puts it overhead, as though he has just taken a house off my back.

I thank him.

He smiles without saying anything.

Sometimes, before there is a conversation, there is already a small logistics of kindness.

After about fifteen minutes, someone offers me a seat. Then a woman gestures for me to move over to the window because she's getting off soon. I sit down and breathe. The train carries on, and my body gives in a little. For a while, I doze off.

Then a girl from the bench opposite gets up and comes to sit beside me. She's a medical student, twenty-three years old, from Kerala. She lived in Dubai for a while, where her parents still are. She tells me she wants to see the world. Alone, if possible.

When I tell her that's exactly what I'm doing, she looks at me as though I'm living proof that some impossible ideas can, after all, buy themselves a ticket.

We exchange Instagram handles.

While we're talking, I notice a man a few benches farther down. He's looking at me. Not the way curious people look at you on trains. Not with that direct, tired gaze, accustomed to strangers, that sees you and then moves on. His gaze stays. It clings to me with a small, dirty persistence, like a hand placed somewhere it has no right to be. He blows kisses at me, makes gestures, smiles in a way that immediately tightens my stomach.

I feel my body change before I even have time to put anything into words: my back straightens, my jaw locks, my hand closes around my phone.

I stare straight at him without smiling.

"What do you want?"

His smile widens.

The girl sees him too.

"People are strange," she says quietly. "Don't mind."

But he doesn't stop.

As she gets ready to leave, the man stands up and moves into the seat opposite me. The distance between us suddenly shrinks.

He doesn't do anything dramatic, and that's exactly what makes me angry: he simply puts his body there, in my way, as though his presence has the right to occupy my air.

That's where the polite part of the day ends.

"Do you speak English?" I ask him.

"Yes."

"Then why are you bothering me?"

He says something about Mangalore. That he's going there too.

"Did I ask you where you were going?"

I lower my feet from the seat, stand up, and move over beside a group of girls one row farther down. The girls look at me.

I make a small gesture towards him.

"I think he's crazy."

They understand. Or at least they understand enough.

The man stays there for a little while longer, watching, assessing the situation, then disappears into the crowd as though the carriage has swallowed him back up.

I'm still furious.

Not scared. Furious.

Furious with him, with his stare, with the way one person can make an entire carriage feel smaller.

Furious with the silence around me too, with the fact that people can see what's happening and nobody says anything.

BRO: "This is serious."

MAYA: "Not now, Bro."

BRO: "Especially now."

Near Mangalore, the young man in the white T-shirt – the one who put my backpack up on the luggage rack – wakes up.

Only then does he start talking. I find out his name is Surya, that he speaks English, that he studies in Mangalore and works in IT.

I tell him about the man from earlier.

He frowns immediately.

"You should have woken me up."

"You were sleeping."

"Still. You should have woken me up."

Then he says, very seriously:

"Pepper spray."

I laugh.

Not because he's wrong, but precisely because he's right.

I see him differently then. Not just as the guy who lifted my backpack, not just as the quiet young man from the carriage, but as someone who, without knowing me at all, takes on a simple, practical concern for a few minutes: next time, I should have something to defend myself with.

We get off together in Mangalore. We walk as far as the large car park, through people, horns, and luggage. He points me in the direction of the city centre, gives me advice, talks quickly, and I understand only half of it – which, I'm beginning to discover, is already a functional form of navigation.

I shake his hand.

"Thank you, Surya."

"Take care of yourself."

I believe him.

I set off towards the mall on foot, convinced I remember the way. Naturally, I don't. I take the wrong street and have to turn back.

I need somewhere to stay as well, so along the way I try about four hotels, but they're all over two thousand rupees.

When I finally reach the mall, where Surya told me I could find something that isn't spicy, the first thing I see is the metal detector at the entrance. I have my backpack on. And there's a knife in it. Right. Not the time to go in there yet. I'm not in the mood for explanations.

Across the road, I spot another hotel. It practically calls out to me.

I cross the street, go inside, and negotiate the room down from 1,650 to 1,500 rupees. It isn't luxurious, but it's on the second floor and looks directly onto the mall.

I leave my backpack there and head out. I'm hungry.

After I eat, I study the map for a while and decide to go to Tannirbhavi Beach, convinced that at least a beach ought to be a simple thing. Naturally, it isn't.

I walk for about two kilometres, cross a stretch of water by boat, then walk all the way across a little island under a sun that has nothing left to prove. When I finally get there, I discover that the beach charges an entrance fee.

I stop. A fee. For the beach.

BRO: "Principles cost money."

MAYA: "That's exactly what I'm refusing."

I don't go in.

Who pays to get to the sea?

So I walk all the way to the end of what appears to be the private section and sit down there instead, on a stretch of wild, undeveloped sand, with no umbrellas, no sun loungers, nobody trying to sell me access to the sea.

The waves are murky, the sun is fierce, I'm sweaty, but at least I haven't paid for something that, in my mind, ought to be free anywhere on the planet.

I take a different route back, another three kilometres or so.

By the time I reach the hotel, I'm drained. I don't want any more city, adventure, discovery, or meaning. I want a shower and a bed.

That evening, from my cheap hotel in Mangalore, I message Surya. I don't have a particularly clear reason. Or maybe I do, but it isn't a practical one.

I've been thinking about him during the day, about the way he first appeared as a gesture – the backpack lifted overhead – and only later as a whole person, with a name, English, concern, and one very practical solution.

Pepper spray, he had said.

It stays between us as a shorthand for care.

I tell him I went to Tannirbhavi Beach – or, more precisely, to its unofficial, entrance-fee-free part – that I'm leaving the city tomorrow, and I ask if he likes reading. I want to send him a PDF of my book about Vietnam, *Days and Nights of Vietnam: The Puzzle of My Soul*. A gift. I'm not entirely sure why. Maybe because, on the train, he did something simple and rare: he paid attention without asking for anything in return.

He replies immediately.

"Yes, ma'am."

I send him the PDF.

"Thank you so much. I will treasure it."

I look at the screen.

BRO: "He said *treasure*."

MAYA: "I saw."

BRO: "About a PDF."

MAYA: "Literature travels in strange ways."

Then, almost immediately, another message appears.

"Can I see you in person?"

I stop, phone in hand.

It's almost ten at night. I'm in my room near City Centre Mall, my legs still tired from all the walking, my skin still remembering the sun, the day almost over.

In any other version of my life, I would have said no. In this one, I write back:

"I can come out for a few minutes if you're nearby."

Apparently, the shower and the bed don't get the final word.

Ten minutes later, he's outside the mall. He appears slim, tall, slightly shy, with the air of someone who somehow doesn't take up much space in the world but leaves something clean around him.

He smiles and hands me a small bag.

"For you, ma'am."

Inside are bangles.

Turquoise.

Beautiful.

The kind of thin, bright bangles worn several at a time, the kind I've seen on Indian women, making a tiny sound whenever the hand moves.

I look at them, then at him.

"Surya…"

I don't know what to say.

Who expects a guy you met on a train, who put your backpack on the luggage rack and recommended pepper spray, to buy you bangles at ten o'clock at night in Mangalore?

I try them on, but they're too small. Of course they are. Reality, whenever it turns tender, makes sure to remain slightly inconvenient.

Surya looks at my hand, then at the bangles.

"We change."

And off we go to change them.

Which is how, at ten o'clock at night, I find myself in a mall in Mangalore, exchanging turquoise bangles with a guy I both know and don't know, after a day that began in a second-class train carriage, continued with a beach I refused on principle, and should, by any reasonable standard, have ended with a shower and a bed.

We find some blue ones, slightly bigger. They fit. They're beautiful. Very beautiful.

We walk around the mall for a little while, then go outside and sit on the kerb in front of it. The city moves past us in lights, scooters, cars, people, horns, warm evening air.

We talk – or try to. He speaks English, and I work hard to understand him. I catch half-sentences, intentions, smiles, approximate meanings. I hope he isn't saying anything terribly important, because a large part of the information is passing me by at the speed of a local bus.

BRO: "International communication."

MAYA: “I’m getting the important bits.”

BRO: “Which are?”

MAYA: “That he’s sweet.”

And he is.

Maybe far too sweet. In that simple, almost disarming way of someone who is happy that you remembered him.

We sit there for maybe half an hour, then he walks me back to the hotel.

I thank him for the bangles and shake his hand.

For a moment, I get the feeling he would like to hug me. I could move closer, but I choose not to. Some forms of closeness should be left exactly where they are: beautiful, brief, and without promises nobody has made.

“Thank you, Surya.”

“Most welcome, ma’am.”

The night slips between us gently.

I go upstairs to my room with the blue bangles in my hand and the feeling that Mangalore, a city where I had planned absolutely nothing, has just given me something small, tangible, impossible to file under *just another coincidence*.

BRO: “Is he why you came here?”

I look at the bangles.

I don’t know.

Maybe for him, maybe for the book, maybe for the absurdity of a woman who complains about everything she already carries with her being given one more thing to wear.

4
I'd Already Been Told

In Gokarna, the cows don't appear – they're already there.

On the beach, in the streets, beside temples, between scooters, in places where any other animal would look lost, but they look like they own the place.

They don't enter the frame. The frame belongs to them.

BRO: "Good. We've reached the bovine administration."

MAYA: "Don't laugh. Cows have social status here."

BRO: "I can tell. You're still looking for a room."

The first place I look at is somewhere up in the middle of nowhere, on a hill, in a half-domesticated version of the jungle. On the map, it had looked close to the centre. The map, as we've already established, doesn't carry a backpack and doesn't smell rooms.

The price is good: eight hundred rupees. It has hot water, with mould as a complimentary extra. I'm beginning to notice that mould isn't necessarily an accommodation problem. It's a recurring character.

The driver doesn't speak English, I don't speak his language, but we understand each other perfectly. I gesture that I'm not staying. He nods with the seriousness of a man who doesn't need the word *mould* to understand that a room isn't for me.

I'd given him four hundred rupees instead of three hundred and fifty, so he immediately becomes concerned with my housing prospects.

He takes me into the centre, to a building with the word *Shakti* written rather faintly on it. The name promises more than a building with old fans and plastic chairs can possibly deliver, but today I'm not looking for revelations. I'm looking for a bed, food, and somewhere my backpack can stop being part of my body.

Shakti is right in the centre, which in Gokarna means it's close to the temple, the restaurants, the sea, and the cows, who move around with full rights.

The driver, helpful to the very end, calls out for someone.

A brisk woman appears, almost running through the corridors, as though the hotel were a living organism and she – its entire circulatory system.

First she shows me a room with no window to the outside.

I refuse.

Then we go upstairs to the top floor, to room 301.

The room has a bed, a ceiling fan, a small table, and a plastic chair in a colour difficult to defend in public: something between brown, beige, and regret. There's no conventional shower, just a bucket standing in for one, but there is hot water, twenty-four hours a day.

At that point, the distinction seems negotiable. I take it.

I leave my luggage in the room and go for a walk towards the temple and then the sea, my eyes moving between shop windows, people, and cows that seem to know where they're going better than I do.

Gokarna doesn't feel like a place made for Europeans. It's touristy, but not for me. Small shops, stalls, simple restaurants, flowers, dust, salt, people who have come for the temple, families, pilgrims, locals, Indians on holiday. I'm more of an accident with a backpack.

On the beach, the waves are big.

People are sitting on the sand.

So are the cows. About ten cows are hanging out on the beach. They aren't passing through, and they don't seem to be looking for

anything. They don't seem lost either. They're just there, as though they have a reservation.

Obviously, I take pictures of them. You can't see ten cows on a beach and behave like a functional adult.

One of them turns its head towards me. It looks at me. Not for long. Just long enough to ruin my sense of superiority and leave me with the ridiculous feeling that I've been noticed by someone who isn't in a hurry to get anywhere.

MAYA: "Bro, that cow looked at me kind of personally."

BRO: "You probably blocked her view of the sea."

MAYA: "I don't think this is about the view."

BRO: "With cows, you never know."

Hunger brings me back to Shakti, where I order rice and a sweet lassi. The boy serving me confirms my choice and stops me from overdoing it when I try to order vegetables as well.

"Big portion, madam."

I believe him.

I appreciate people who save your budget before they save your digestion.

I'm sitting alone when a young woman appears and takes the table opposite mine. She's beautiful, wearing cream trousers and a black T-shirt, her hair loose to her shoulders and her eyes outlined in black. There's something urban about her, something self-assured, difficult to place on my hastily assembled map.

I wonder if she's from India.

I watch her gesture to the waiter and say something. She catches my eye and smiles.

"What happened?" I ask, without realising that I've just opened the next door of the day.

From there, the conversation rolls along by itself.

I invite her to join me.

Her name is Akanksha. She's twenty-six and from Mumbai – from Navi Mumbai, I'll learn later. She's been travelling alone for a few

weeks, works online as a health coach, has been to the United States, loved Argentina, and moves through the world with the air of a woman for whom approval is optional.

We talk at the table, then on the steps outside Shakti, then through town, with a coconut between us and Gokarna slowly unfolding around the edges.

She talks quickly, I catch the meaning in pieces, and the town seems to fill in whatever I don't understand.

"You know why it is called Gokarna?" Akanksha asks me.

I don't.

She explains it simply, as though she's telling me something the place has been showing me all along and I just haven't known how to read.

"*Go* comes from cow," she says. "*Karna* means ear. Gokarna – cow's ear."

I look around: at the cow beside the road, the one lying outside a shop, another walking past us with the slow gait of a creature that has never once asked permission to exist in the middle of traffic.

Suddenly, what looked like scenery begins to resemble an alphabet.

BRO: "You got subtitles?"

MAYA: "I think so."

BRO: "Let's see when you learn to read them."

Ahead of us, a cow stops.

It doesn't do anything. That is, in fact, the strange part.

It doesn't moo, doesn't ask for anything, doesn't startle, doesn't look for food. It just stands there, slightly off to one side, its head turned towards us, as though it caught the last sentence and isn't entirely convinced I understood it correctly.

Akanksha doesn't even seem to notice. To her, a cow standing in the middle of the road is part of the town's furniture. To me, it's beginning to look suspicious.

MAYA: "Bro."

BRO: "No."

MAYA: "I didn't say anything."

BRO: "You were about to say the cow is trying to tell you something."

MAYA: "What if it is?"

BRO: "Then I hope it speaks clearly, because you need things repeated."

The cow looks at me for another moment, then walks away. Slowly, like someone who has done their duty.

Akanksha keeps talking, and I listen, except now I'm listening to the town underneath her voice as well.

We walk slowly through the narrow streets, past little shops, the smell of hot oil, flowers for the temple, and cows appearing at corners like living commas.

We head back to Shakti as the town begins to fold itself into evening. We talk for a little while longer, then part on the steps with a promise that when I get to Mumbai and she finishes her holiday in Gokarna, we'll go out to a club and take photos of me in one of her mother's saris.

In Gokarna, promises don't sound like plans. They sound like scenes set aside to see whether reality will still be interested in them when their turn comes.

Later, at the restaurant at Shakti, I ask about an omelette, and the boy tells me they don't have eggs. Not just here. Anywhere on the street.

"Vegetarian street, madam. Because temple."

Right.

In Gokarna, even eggs have traffic regulations.

I order porridge with banana and coffee. The coffee, after so many chapters of pursuit, finally appears in a place where eggs are impossible.

BRO: "You got your coffee."

MAYA: "Without an omelette."

BRO: “Progress requires sacrifice.”

With the coffee in front of me, I start figuring out how to leave. I open the map, and Goa, which until now has been one big, round, almost mythical word, begins to break apart into names: South Goa, North Goa, Canacona, Palolem, Agonda, Anjuna, Vagator.

Beaches, villages, distances, buses, blue dots that refuse to move properly.

MAYA: “Bro, what actually is Goa?”

BRO: “First of all, it’s not a city.”

MAYA: “Obviously I knew that.”

BRO: “You did not know that.”

MAYA: “I suspected it culturally.”

I read, zoom in, zoom out, lose the map.

South Goa seems slower. Palolem has more life. Agonda seems quieter. Canacona is where I need to get off. The rest, obviously, will be decided by some combination of exhaustion, budget, maps, and coffee.

BRO: “So tomorrow you take the bus.”

MAYA: “How far?”

BRO: “As far as reality lets you.”

MAYA: “Very helpful.”

BRO: ”Get off at Canacona. After that, improvise with an air of strategy.”

Later, when I go upstairs to my room, Gokarna is already a different town.

By day, it belongs to the temple, the cows, the coconuts, the little restaurants, and the women walking slowly past the stalls. At night, though, the building breathes differently. The shared balcony fills with shadows, the fan in room 301 does its job with the aggression of a tired helicopter, and my clothes hang over that impossible chair like witnesses with no interest in giving statements.

When I sit on the bed with my laptop in my lap to do a little more writing, I hear strange sounds coming from the street. At

first, I can't work out what they are. They don't sound like human voices, or traffic, or any animal I can immediately identify. They come infrequently, irregularly, from different places, like replies in a conversation I don't understand.

I get up and look out of the window. The street is deserted. No cars. No people. Just three cows, scattered across the road with no apparent logic, each standing in a different place. They aren't together, but they're mooing to one another, long and strange, as though the night has finally given them the right to speak. I hadn't heard them at all during the day.

The man staying next to my room is standing on the balcony with a towel wrapped around his waist, talking on the phone. I pay no attention to him. After trains, mould, cows calling to one another in the dark, and a town where even eggs have traffic regulations, a man in a towel on the balcony does not automatically qualify as an event.

Reality, however, always insists on adding a footnote.

Much later, when the room has grown hot, the town has gone quiet, and I'm trying to convince my body that the hard bed is still, technically, a bed, I notice something red beside the leg of the chair, right underneath my yellow trousers.

Small. Square. Shiny.

I move closer to the door and look. It's a condom. Unopened. Most likely slipped under the door.

I look at it, then at the door, then back at it.

BRO: "This is serious."

MAYA: "I'm not sure if it's serious or optimistic."

The joke comes quickly, but my body is a second behind.

I listen to the corridor. The door suddenly seems thinner than it did a minute ago.

I think about the neighbour in the towel. The shared balcony. The fact that my door opens directly onto the corridor and that, apparently, non-verbal communication in Gokarna can also involve flat objects pushed underneath doors.

In the town where cows have full rights, someone has decided that a strategically placed condom beneath my yellow trousers constitutes a reasonable invitation.

I laugh. I laugh because otherwise I'd have to understand something.

And at two in the morning, after cows, the temple, Akanksha, Goa, the impossible omelette, and the fan, I no longer have the energy to understand strange men.

BRO: "Souvenir from Gokarna."

MAYA: "Gokarna has its methods."

BRO: "And unsolicited initiatives."

Gokarna doesn't put on a show.

Not like Fort Kochi.

It doesn't come with Safi, carpets, Guinness-record perfumes, and imaginary houses furnished on the go. Gokarna works more slowly. It keeps putting cows in the frame until they stop looking like scenery. It brings you a girl from Mumbai who explains, almost in passing, that the name of the place begins with a cow. It refuses you an omelette for local reasons. It slips a condom under your door, just to stop you from getting too carried away by the symbolism.

I think I notice things.

In fact, I'm being given the script in pieces.

BRO: "The problem isn't that you don't get signs."

MAYA: "What's the problem?"

BRO: "You read them after the premiere."

I still know nothing about the Cow on the Red Carpet.

Gokarna gives me the subtitles.

Goa will start the film.

5

The Cow on the Red Carpet

I leave Gokarna with a little bottle of coffee in my backpack and the cows strolling lazily down the middle of the road, as though the town isn't leading me to the bus but handing me over to whatever comes next.

The cows don't say anything, obviously. But after Gokarna, their silence is beginning to feel administrative.

I don't drink the coffee straight away. I've learned something: you drink coffee after you find the bus, after you get on, and after you're sure you're actually heading in the direction you think you are – which is already an advanced form of optimism.

BRO: "You've developed rituals."

MAYA: "They're called survival mechanisms."

There are two buses at the station and not a single word I can read with confidence. Schoolchildren in uniform, girls with braids, boys with backpacks, men in brown clothes. A counter that doesn't look like a ticket office, but plenty of things don't look like what they are and still somehow work.

I walk over.

"Canacona?"

One of the men says something to the other. The other looks at me, then at the bus in front of us.

"No bus direct, madam. Go to Ankola. There bus."

"Ankola?"

"Ankola. Many buses there."

That's it.

No map, no explanation, no route. Just *Ankola*, delivered with the authority of a place where buses apparently multiply on their own.

I get on the bus he pointed to, take the first seat, and put my backpack overhead. There are about ten people inside.

A man comes around collecting fares.

"Ankola. Thirty-three rupees."

Only then do I open the map.

I look at the blue dot, then at the road. It looks as though I'm going backwards.

Not a little. A lot.

The kind of backwards that makes your entire personality feel betrayed by public transport.

I get up, leave my backpack overhead, and go back to the counter with the dignity of a woman who has been deceived by geography too many times.

"Are you sure? I want Goa. Canacona. There's no direct bus?"

The man doesn't even blink.

"Ankola. Many buses."

That's it.

I go back to the bus.

BRO: "You got an answer."

MAYA: "I got a sentence."

BRO: "With a connection."

A few minutes later, we set off. The bus fills with schoolchildren, shopping bags, people getting on and off without giving the slightest impression that any of them require explanations.

I check the map again, ready to confirm the tragedy. And that's when I realise we're not going backwards. We're going the right way.

I'd selected the wrong town on the map.

For a few seconds, I sit there with the phone in my hand and simply stare at it, in that special kind of silence in which you discover that the chaos outside has, in fact, had an inside collaborator all along.

BRO: "So the system was innocent?"

MAYA: "Let's not get carried away."

BRO: "Partially innocent."

MAYA: "Partially."

Forty minutes later, we reach Ankola. One of the men gestures to me.

"There, madam. Platform one. Wait there for Goa."

So, in the end, all is well.

No bus. There bus. Wait, madam.

There's no bus at platform one, but there are plenty of people waiting. An older man asks me where I'm going.

"Canacona."

"Here. Platform one. Nine fifteen. You have time."

I have time.

When someone tells you that you have time, you never know whether it's good news or a warning.

The bus appears at nine thirteen, two minutes before the situation can become philosophical.

I ask one more time, just to be sure.

Yes. This is it.

I get on last. Mistake. There are no seats left. The aisle is already packed. I squeeze towards the back, next to a handrail, with my backpack on the floor, my laptop bag over my shoulder, and my right hand – the one with the wrist I injured a year ago – forced to hold on for dear life. At every pothole, it protests.

I pay one hundred and thirty-five rupees. Then the journey begins. I can't really call it a journey. It's a violent negotiation between the bus, the potholes, the hairpin bends, and my spine. As the bus begins to empty out, I eventually manage to get a seat.

At a place called Manjali, the conductor signals that we'll be stopping for half an hour.

I don't get off. A seat on a bus is real estate. You don't give it up without a very good reason.

An older woman gets on carrying a large plastic crate and three big shopping bags. A sheet has been stretched over the crate and tied tightly with thick string, like an improvised lid.

I can't see what's inside. The crate has the air of an object that knows it is going to become somebody's problem. That somebody, obviously, will be me.

She puts the crate next to my backpack.

As we approach Canacona, the conductor gestures to me.

"Canacona."

I get up quickly.

The woman with the crate gets up too. The conductor helps her unload the crate and the bags. I get off after them.

The bus drives away.

The two of us are left standing by the side of the road. There's no bus stop, no town in sight, and no tuk-tuk – just a field, a fork in the road, and the feeling that before Goa lets you in, it checks whether you can carry something.

The woman looks at the crate.

I look at the crate.

"Help?" I ask.

She smiles.

"Yes."

Of course.

We lift the crate together. After seven steps, I understand that the crate does not contain things. It contains destiny. The edge digs into my palm, and I signal that we should put it down.

The woman takes out a scarf and folds it over the edge on my side, then does the same on hers. She seems calm, practical, and

accustomed to burdens that don't announce in advance how much they weigh.

We carry it a little farther. Far enough to cross the road. Far enough for me to remember that I have no idea where I'm going. She seems to know. I don't.

A man appears on a scooter with a child sitting in front of him. He stops beside us, speaks to the woman, then looks at me.

"Where are you going? Taxi?"

"Uhhh."

I open the map.

Because apparently, I've arrived in Goa without actually deciding what I'm going to do in Goa.

The first saved pin that catches my eye is Agonda.

"Agonda," I say.

The man looks at me as though I've just suggested walking to Nepal.

"Agonda far. Twelve kilometres. Here Palolem. Patnem also."

Palolem.

I suddenly remember the map in Gokarna. Canacona. Palolem. The idea that the rest would be decided somewhere between exhaustion, budget, maps, and the first coffee.

The coffee, obviously, had been drunk on the bus and had decided nothing.

"Yes, yes. Palolem."

The man leaves.

No taxi appears, no tuk-tuk, and no sign whatsoever that Goa has any logistical intentions towards me. I look right. I look left. Road, heat, backpack, and the map, which tells me it's a twenty-five-minute walk to the first accommodation I've saved.

Twenty-five minutes.

My map, naturally, is always backpack-free.

I say goodbye to the woman, she smiles, and I set off in the direction the GPS tells me to go. The heat isn't heat. It's a transparent

substance that enters my body and comes out wherever it can. It runs down my face, my back, my neck. The humidity clings to me with an intimacy I did not approve.

My backpack doubles in weight every hundred metres, and my laptop bag begins to develop political opinions about my shoulder.

Goa, in the collective imagination, has beaches, cafés, sunsets, and barefoot people.

So far, Goa has a road with no shade, a woman with an impossible crate, and me, walking towards Palolem with the feeling that I've been delivered to the wrong address but accepted into the system anyway.

BRO: "Welcome to Goa."

MAYA: "I don't feel welcomed."

BRO: "You're still taking the entrance exam."

Near the accommodation I'd saved on the map – something with *Piccolo* in the name – I spot a tiny café on the right, with only four tables. It has a bohemian, European feel and that dangerous promise that someone, somewhere, knows how to make milk foam.

At that moment, the accommodation in my head loses all importance. I no longer want a room. I want coffee.

I walk in with the face of someone Goa decided to boil first and admit as a tourist afterwards.

The girl at the café takes one look at me and says just one thing:

"Water? Cold?"

"Yessss."

I wouldn't want to look in a mirror right now, but I probably resemble a boiled lobster that's been taken out for a walk with a laptop.

She brings me cold water.

I ask if I can pay by UPI. I realise I've arrived in Goa with very little cash, which traditionally is exactly the moment when every QR code begins to develop a personality of its own. The girl says yes, and I order a cheese tart and a cappuccino.

And then it happens.

My first proper coffee in Goa isn't good.

It's flawless.

More than that: it is indecently good for someone who, twenty minutes earlier, had been dropped by the side of the road next to a woman with an impossible crate. The cappuccino arrives with a heart in the foam, as though Goa has decided to repair my spine through aesthetics.

BRO: "Careful. It's flirting."

MAYA: "Who?"

BRO: "Goa."

MAYA: "With coffee?"

BRO: "Aggressively."

The tart is sublime, and the coffee is so good that I send photos to my friends, because some miracles need social validation before they disappear.

A man, probably the owner, asks me how the coffee is. I look at him. Do you really have to ask?

While I'm there, I call the place with *Piccolo* in the name.

Actually, I don't want to call. I only want to send a WhatsApp message, but I tap the wrong thing and the man calls me back, which, in my current state, is already far too much synchronous communication.

I tell him I want a room.

"Wait," he says.

He isn't at the property.

"I'll be there in three minutes," I say. "I'll wait for you."

I get up to pay.

The man shows me the QR code. Personal account, which my app won't accept.

Of course.

"Do you have another code?"

"No problem," he says. "On the house."

I look at him.

"Sorry?"

"Coffee, tart. No problem. Don't pay."

This, I have to admit, catches me completely off guard.

After the buses, the potholes, the heat, the backpack, the crate, the map, and the walk, the first café I enter in Palolem gives me cold water, perfect coffee, a cheese tart – and then refuses to take my money.

BRO: "Let's recap: you went in to pay and were spared."

MAYA: "I don't know what for."

BRO: "Goa probably doesn't either."

I walk out laughing.

The first good surprise of the day.

And the day had barely begun its performance.

Less than a hundred and fifty metres away is the Piccolo place. On the map, it had looked like an option. In reality, it looks like an unfinished idea.

There are workers in the courtyard, building materials, dust, noise – a construction-site chaos that isn't even trying to look hospitable.

A woman who looks European comes out, gets into a car, and drives away without looking at me. There's a large house visible at the back.

I send a message:

I'm here.

A young man appears from the courtyard.

"You want room?"

"Yes. I want to see it."

"Come. I help you with luggage."

I don't protest.

After that walk through the heat, my backpack is no longer luggage. It's a sentence with zips.

He takes it and puts it on his back, then leads me up the outside stairs, apologising as we go.

"Construction, madam. Sorry. Not season."

The rooms, I quickly realise, aren't ready.

The first one smells of mould.

"No."

The second one smells of cigarette smoke.

"Still no."

The third is downstairs, where the construction site appears to have already won.

"Not season. We make bar. Rooms not ready."

It's monsoon season, the time of year when Goa repairs everything that, come summer, it will pretend was ready all along.

His brother appears too, on a motorbike.

"You like room?"

"Not really. Sorry."

He doesn't push, doesn't get annoyed, but tells me I can leave my luggage there while I look for somewhere else. I smile and thank him for being kind, but no, I'm not leaving it. Not because they don't seem like good people, but because my relationship with my backpack is toxic but stable.

I head towards the next place I've saved, which looks close to the beach on the map, and I'm already beginning to dream of palm trees and blue waves. Five hundred metres to go, which looks like a joke on the map. In reality, the road climbs, dips, heats up, sticks to my feet, and with every step extracts a small amount of regret for every object I have ever considered necessary.

At a corner, I spot a colourful café: lots of yellow things hanging everywhere, an open terrace, a little fence, the kind of place that looks as though it knows how to sell lassi, coffee, and the illusion that life can be repaired in the shade. I tell myself I'll try it after I find somewhere to stay, which, in my current state, sounds like a promise made to a more stable version of myself.

Then a man with curly hair down to his shoulders comes out.

He doesn't come out in a hurry, or with any aggressive curiosity, but with the air of someone who has been standing at that crossroads

for a long time and knows that people with large backpacks never pass by entirely by accident.

"Where are you going?"

I stop.

"I'm looking for a place to stay. I saw Brahmina."

"Brahma," he corrects me.

Right.

In Goa, even accommodation refuses to be called by the wrong name.

"I know it. What's your budget?"

"Eight hundred."

Then I add, because suffering produces audacity:

"A thousand if it has air conditioning and a sea view."

And I grin, already imagining the view.

The man looks at me with a calm I don't yet know how to interpret. He doesn't laugh at my budget, which in itself feels like an advanced form of politeness.

He simply points towards a street, as though somewhere there, among the dust, palm trees, and poorly marked buildings, a solution is waiting.

"Look there. Good rooms. Good price."

"Not that sign?"

"No, no. Before that. On the right."

I haven't understood him particularly well, which doesn't stop me from setting off.

I'm beginning to notice that on certain days, finding your way doesn't come from clarity but from being too tired to ask any more questions.

After a few steps, I turn back slightly and call out:

"Should I say you sent me?"

He laughs.

His laughter stays behind, caught on the corner of the yellow café, while I keep walking, not knowing that the place isn't finished with me yet.

I climb the hill he pointed out.

Horrible.

The kind of hill that makes you understand immediately that a cheap room can become expensive if you have to reach it three times a day. With every step, my backpack becomes more of an enemy, and every metre takes away another illusion I had about life near the beach.

There's nobody at the top. The reception is empty, with no clear sign that the place is expecting me or has ever even heard of me. I wander around for a little while in that silence of possible accommodation and decide I don't need a room that requires me to train both my calves and my faith in promises.

I head back down before anyone appears to convince me that the hill is *very easy*, *madam*.

I go to Brahma.

Or Brahmina, as I'd christened it in my state of decomposition.

I arrive sweating, with my backpack stuck to my back and my bladder having reached the level of a diplomatic emergency.

The man is busy with two guests, but he looks up at me.

"Room?"

He shakes his head.

"Today we're full."

No.

I refuse to believe this.

After the whole journey, after the free coffee, after the construction site, after the pointless hill, Goa tells me, with murderous serenity, that this place is full too.

At that point, I'm no longer looking for accommodation.

I'm looking for a toilet.

"Toilet? Please?"

The man gestures for me to wait a moment, then takes me upstairs to one of the rooms that has just been vacated and hasn't been cleaned yet. I don't care. The room could look like a crime scene. I have exactly one mission in there.

I come back downstairs relieved, thank him, pick up my backpack, and leave.

This isn't my place either.

So I head uphill again, up the same slope I've just come down, with a backpack that no longer weighs fifteen kilos. It has a past, a present, and debts I don't remember taking on but am apparently carrying anyway.

BRO: "Goa is testing you."

MAYA: "Goa can get itself a form."

BRO: "You haven't reached the Department of Absurdity yet."

MAYA: "There's another department further up?"

BRO: "Yes. It has lassi and a cow at the entrance."

I go back to the yellow café.

It's called Yellow's Cafe, which partly explains why the curly-haired man had emerged from it with the air of someone who owns not only a café but also a small piece of the street's chaos.

I ask for a menu and sit down on a daybed covered in colourful cushions. My backpack collapses against the wall before I do, as though it too has decided that from this point on, we proceed by negotiation only.

When he sees me, the man asks:

"Did you find a room?"

I indicate the disaster beside the wall with my eyes.

"No. I came back to have something cold because I can't do this anymore. Then I'll see. I'll go the other way."

I make a vague gesture with my hand, the kind people use to inform a map that they're tired of respecting it.

Then I order a sweet lassi.

The man disappears into the back.

I'm left holding my phone, but not for the map. At that moment, the map has lost the moral right to give me directions.

I sit on the daybed at Yellow's Cafe, my glass of lassi in front of me, my backpack collapsed beside the wall, with the very clear feeling that Goa has admitted me into the state but not yet into its personal life.

BRO: "Of course I'm laughing."

MAYA: "Why?"

BRO: "Your tropical paradise started with a logistics audit."

MAYA: "It started with a woman and a crate."

BRO: "Initiatory."

MAYA: "And a perfect coffee they wouldn't let me pay for."

BRO: "Suspicious."

MAYA: "Then mould, fully booked, an emergency toilet stop, and that hill again."

BRO: "Goa is showing you the paperwork first."

MAYA: "I wanted a beach. Goa won't let me dream yet."

BRO: "You got procedure."

MAYA: "Who guarantees the other places won't be the same?"

BRO: "Nobody. That's the beautiful part."

MAYA: "It's not beautiful. It's sweaty."

BRO: "Because you're carrying it on your back."

MAYA: "I can find something good even in a snake hole. But it's nice to have someone to laugh with."

BRO: "I'm not worried about you. I'm worried about the snake."

That's when I look up.

There's a cow standing at the entrance to the café.

Yes.

A cow.

There's no door, just an opening, a little fence, the street, and her. The cow doesn't come in, doesn't leave, doesn't ask for anything. She stands at the edge of the café with perfect seriousness, as though Yellow's Cafe has, in addition to a menu, its own entry regulations.

Her head is tilted slightly to one side, almost inquisitively, for a creature chewing without hurry.

I take a photo of her.

Obviously.

Not to prove anything to anyone, but because some absurdities need to be preserved before they start sounding like literary exaggeration.

BRO: "Border control."

MAYA: "She doesn't seem impressed by me."

BRO: "You don't even have an address yet."

MAYA: "Do you think she'll let me into Goa?"

BRO: "Depends. Do you have the form?"

MAYA: "I have lassi."

BRO: "Insufficient, but promising."

I look at the Cow, at the lassi, then at my backpack collapsed against the wall.

The Cow looks more relaxed than I am. I haven't found anywhere to stay, but she already seems to know where she's sleeping tonight.

I take another photo of her.

Then I take one of myself too, for the record: sweaty face, the eyes of someone who has negotiated too much with geography, hair stuck to my temples, dignity in recovery.

The photo of the lassi follows naturally, because every serious investigation requires evidence.

I look at the three images on the screen: the cow, me, the lassi.

BRO: "Three frames from the same film."

MAYA: "Title?"

BRO: "*Do You Have a Reservation or Are You Going on Instinct?*"

MAYA: "That's the cow's line?"

BRO: "Obviously. You're negotiating with hope. The lassi is the protected witness."

I sit on the daybed, the cold glass in front of me, the cow at the entrance and my backpack against the wall, in a configuration no travel agency would dare put in a brochure.

And suddenly, I find it very funny. Not practical, not resolved, not comfortable.

Funny.

MAYA: "It would have been much easier if the bus had dropped me outside a perfect place to stay and I'd gone straight to a sun lounger."

BRO: "After two days, you'd have asked who was coming onstage."

MAYA: "I'm not that bad."

BRO: "Comfort keeps you occupied for two days. After that, you start looking for characters."

I laugh.

I actually laugh.

I look at the Cow at the entrance. She's still there, perfectly still, watching me with the air of someone approving my official report.

BRO: "Abandoning bus, habitable construction site, Cow inspector, and rescue lassi. You've got a cast."

MAYA: "Material, you mean."

BRO: "Goa hasn't even had its coffee yet."

I remember my first coffee in Goa, the one with the heart in the foam, drunk just a few minutes before I walked into the construction-site accommodation. I pull up the photo on my screen: flawless cappuccino, white heart, little table, good light. Almost indecent proof that the day knew how to be beautiful even while behaving badly.

MAYA: "Still, my first coffee in Goa was perfect."

BRO: "Exactly. Goa told you: *I'll give you coffee, but I'm not giving you a place yet*."

MAYA: "And I didn't even pay for it."

Pause.

I can almost feel Bro lifting his head.

MAYA: "UPI wouldn't work with a personal account. The guy said it was on the house. Coffee and cheese tart. Anything else to say?"

BRO: "You're not travelling anymore. You're already in the chapter."

MAYA: "You're exaggerating."

BRO: "No. I'm reading the transcript."

I laugh again.

In the absence of any concrete plan, the yellow café has become a kind of courtroom for the absurd.

BRO: "You think Goa doesn't want you. Goa just has a questionable sense of humour."

MAYA: "By tonight, I'm going to walk around and find Goa's hidden accommodation."

BRO: "Correct. When things become ridiculously complicated, something absurdly simple usually comes next."

I look at the backpack, but the backpack doesn't seem convinced.

BRO: "If by tonight you find a room in a place so improbable that the only decent reaction is *of course*, I'll consider Goa's work done."

I don't know it yet, but reality is reading over my shoulder and taking notes.

MAYA: "Maya and India. A book to be feared."

BRO: "No. *Maya and India* isn't a book. It's a literary threat."

A laugh escapes me so loudly that for a second I look around to see if anyone heard.

It doesn't matter anymore.

There's a cow at the entrance.

If there is such a thing as a competent audience for absurdity, the Cow is it.

MAYA: "I have photos."

BRO: "Exactly. The chapter can defend itself."

For a few minutes, I completely forget that I have nowhere to sleep.

That may be the most dangerous form of comfort: not the bed, not the shower, not the room, not the air conditioning, but the moment when disaster becomes tellable.

At that moment, I almost don't need accommodation anymore.

Almost.

Because the backpack, leaning against the wall, has a different opinion.

Just then, the curly-haired man appears beside the daybed.

"Relax. There's an apartment across the road. I'll show you. No hurry."

I look at him.

Relax is a very beautiful word when someone else isn't carrying it on their back.

I look at my backpack. My backpack looks back at me with the full weight of its traumatic history.

"Can I leave it here?" I ask.

The man makes a broad gesture towards the café.

"Leave it. No problem. Finish your lassi. Then we go."

Normally, I would analyse, weigh things up, convene my little internal committee on safety, paranoia, and common sense, but at that moment the committee is on holiday.

The backpack stays against the wall, under the supervision of the Cow, who seems far more competent than any reception desk I've seen all day.

I take the last few sips of my lassi.

BRO: "I told you. After the chaos, something absurdly simple."

MAYA: "We don't know if it's simple yet. It could be a ghost apartment."

BRO: "The solution was across the road. That's already suspiciously simple."

MAYA: "Wait till we see it. Maybe it has dust, man-eating spiders, and smells of mould."

BRO: "If it has a shower, Wi-Fi, and air conditioning, Goa is directing this."

MAYA: "I'm dying. You make it sound like Goa is directing a live comedy-drama."

BRO: "Not Booking. Not Agoda. Not Google Maps. A man sees you sweating and says: *Sister*, *apartment there*."

I put my phone in my bag and get up.

The empty lassi glass stays on the table, the backpack remains under bovine guard, and the people there can barely get the Cow to move away from the entrance so we can get out.

I cross the road behind the curly-haired man, in a state where I no longer know whether I'm going to look at a room or walk into a local joke.

The house across the road doesn't look like accommodation. There are no signs, no reception, nothing visible to suggest that anything here is organised. It looks like a large two-storey house caught completely unprepared by the idea of tourism. We climb some steps along the left side of the house and reach the upper floor, where there's a long, wide terrace open towards the street.

There are two brown wooden doors: one straight ahead, one to the right.

The man opens the door in front of us and we go inside.

First he shows me a small room with air conditioning and tells me he thinks this one would suit me.

I know. I should choose the air conditioning. Obviously, I don't choose the air conditioning. I choose the larger room next to it, the one I noticed the moment we came in, with the door wide open and a fan, because after so many hours of my backpack altering my personality, I need space, not intelligence.

The room is charming and colourful, with a huge bed and elegant furniture. I like it. I like it immediately, which, after so many rejections, feels almost suspicious.

The man gives me a quick tour of the house: an enormous living room, about the size of three normal rooms, a kitchen, then the bathroom. I automatically assume these are shared spaces. It feels like a large house occupied in pieces, not something that could possibly have anything to do with me as a whole.

In my head, I'm renting the big room with the fan.

Everything else is scenery.

"Needs cleaning," he says. "No clients. No clean."

I look at him.

There's no attempt at marketing, no poetry, no *special monsoon price*, just the naked truth in flip-flops:

No clients, no clean.

I really like this man.

I ask how much the room with the fan is.

"One thousand."

I look at him and smile.

"No air conditioning. Bathroom is far. Nine hundred?"

"Bathroom is there," he says, pointing towards the hall. "Everyone goes there."

At the time, I don't understand what *everyone* means.

I'm too busy negotiating with the last of my strength.

"Nine hundred. I stay three nights."

We're already at the door, about to leave.

He looks at me without smiling, then says:

"Fine."

By my quick calculations, I'm about to pay two thousand seven hundred rupees for a large room, a fan, hot water, three beaches at my disposal, and a man who doesn't lie even when it would be profitable.

We head back to the café.

The curly-haired man, whose name, I would later learn, is Cesare, tells me to wait while he sends someone over to clean.

I pay for the lassi – one hundred and twenty rupees – by UPI and sit down on the same daybed. I already feel much lighter, even though

my backpack is still against the wall. Sometimes you don't get rid of the weight; you simply find out there's somewhere, at least, where you can put it down.

In my head, everything is clear: Cesare has a house across the road, maybe he lives there too, maybe he rents out a room now and then when the opportunity arises, and I've just been given the large room with the fan.

The rest of the house – the enormous living room, the kitchen, the bathroom – naturally falls into the category of shared spaces, that area of life where you don't ask too many questions in case the answers become complicated.

MAYA: "*No clients. No clean.* Good story?"

BRO: "Flawless. Four words and not a gram of marketing."

MAYA: "And I chose the big room with the fan instead of the small one with air conditioning."

BRO: "Thirty-four degrees, nine hundred per cent humidity. Maya: *Space matters.*"

MAYA: "It does."

BRO: "Thermal consistency."

MAYA: "Let's recap. At the first café, I got a free cappuccino and tart. At the second, lassi and a room across the road. Should I try a third, or stop here?"

BRO: "No. There's a real risk that at the third one you'll be given a camel, an invitation to Rajasthan, a marriage proposal, or a publishing contract."

MAYA: "The way this day is going, if I stay a little longer, Cesare will turn up with a ring."

BRO: "Exactly. Stop at the lassi."

I'm ruling nothing out.

I think about going to the beach while the cleaning is being done, but Cesare stops me immediately.

"No. After five. You're tired. Go and rest. Someone is there."

He says it so firmly that for a moment I get the impression that five o'clock isn't a recommendation but a local law.

I listen to him. And the fact that I'm taking instructions from a man I've known for twenty minutes says something about my general condition.

When I pick up my backpack, I instinctively hold it out to him.

"Heavy."

He lifts it slightly, looks at me, and says:

"You're strong."

I don't know whether he means the backpack or me. Either way, both of us needed to be put down.

I smile, put it on my back, and head upstairs to my new room.

Upstairs, a sturdy woman is cleaning the bathroom. The bed in the large room already has fresh, clean sheets. I drop my backpack beside the window and turn on the fan.

The fan spins on setting one. That's it.

In a room in Goa, at the hour when the walls seem to have boiled from the inside, setting one isn't ventilation. It's an opinion.

I go over to the woman and point at the fan.

"More?" I ask.

She doesn't speak English. She points outside.

"Boss. Boss."

Right.

Then she comes with me and shows me the small room, the one with air conditioning. It's still cool inside from our first visit, when Cesare turned the AC on. At that moment, all my principles about space, dignity, and large rooms quietly melt away.

I go back down to the café.

Cesare is at the entrance.

"The fan doesn't work. Can I take the room with air conditioning?"

He looks at me calmly.

"I told you. Take AC room."

It's difficult to argue with a man who was right from the beginning.

I go back upstairs. The woman is already making the bed in the new room. I move my luggage in, lock the door, and have just enough time to change when someone knocks.

I open the door.

The cleaning woman holds out a keyring with two keys.

"Door. Close."

She points to the front door, then to one of the keys.

I understand: that's the key I use to lock it.

I look at her.

"Do I have to lock it... or what?"

She gives a slight shrug, with a degree of freedom I find unsettling.

I take the gesture to mean: whatever I want.

And she leaves.

I'm left standing there with the keys in my hand. I go back into my room, close the door, sit on the bed, and stare at the keyring.

Why did she give me the key to the front door too?

And then I understand.

The living room, the kitchen, the bathroom, the hall, the front door – they weren't shared spaces.

They were mine.

I laugh for quite a while.

Bro is silent for a second. Which, in itself, is serious.

MAYA: "Guess what?"

BRO: "No. I refuse to guess. Your reality beats every prediction. Tell me."

MAYA: "It's not just a room for nine hundred with the bathroom down the hall."

I look around, just to make sure I'm not exaggerating.

I'm not.

MAYA: "It's the whole apartment. Cesare said he rents it for five or six thousand in season. He asked me for a thousand, and I negotiated him down to nine hundred."

BRO: "No. I refuse to accept this script. You were looking for a room, and Goa was preparing an apartment for you."

That makes me laugh again. I'm not laughing the way I was earlier, from exhaustion. Now I'm laughing at the sheer disproportion of it.

BRO: "And the part that kills me is the negotiation. Six-thousand-rupee apartment. Man says one thousand. Maya says nine hundred. Man: *fine*. You were negotiating *the room*; he was negotiating *the apartment*."

BRO: "An editor would cut this scene and write in the margin: *Too implausible. Reduce the character's luck.*"

I start reconstructing the whole thing, just to make sure my memory won't later try to impose order where there wasn't any.

I cross the road. The curly-haired man comes out of the café and asks where I'm going. I tell him I'm looking for somewhere to stay. He sends me somewhere. I find nothing. I go to Brahma. Full. I go back to him only because I want something cold to drink. He sees me, asks if I found anything. I say no, but I'll keep looking. I sit down, drink lassi, take photos of the Cow. He disappears for a while, then comes back and says: apartment across the road.

That's it.

That is the entire operation.

No strategy, no plan, no algorithm – just a woman with a backpack, a yellow café, a cow, and a man who asked the right question at the right moment.

BRO: "Exactly. It all starts with: *Where are you going?*"

MAYA: "And I didn't even know."

BRO: "That's precisely why it worked."

Only then do I remember something else more clearly: after the first cow left, another one came along, smaller than the first.

She stopped at the entrance too and looked at me with the same administrative seriousness.

Two cows. Not one.

In Palolem, even the signs worked in shifts.

Cesare had shooed both of them away from the entrance without any drama, like overly persistent customers.

I, of course, hadn't known how to read the moment.

BRO: "Cow No. 1: reception."

BRO: "Cow No. 2: quality control."

MAYA: "They were staring at me."

BRO: "Checking your file."

MAYA: "What can I say? The local administration is keeping a close eye on me."

BRO: "At street level. With horns."

Later, on one of my trips between the café and the apartment, Cesare tells me a few things about himself with the same simplicity with which he'd told me: *No clients. No clean.*

He's single. He doesn't really travel. He went to Gokarna once, about ten years ago.

None of this information is of any use to me, which is precisely what makes him real. He isn't trying to be interesting. He simply exists, in flip-flops, somewhere between the café, the house, two cows, and an apartment he has just given me for the price of a room.

So, I have accommodation.

Not a room.

An apartment.

All to myself.

A princess, but with a backpack.

I go downstairs to ask for his phone number so I don't have to keep commuting between the apartment and the café every time I have a question.

I'm wearing shorts, still in that state of someone who has secured accommodation but lost all interest in protocol. Cesare and another employee hesitate for a fraction of a second.

I see it.

They pretend it didn't happen.

I pretend I didn't see it.

Sometimes civilisation is preserved through well-managed silences.

Cesare says he'll come by later to fix the fan in the large room.

After a while, three men appear. They come in, go out, check the fan, the electrics, and the rooms, like a small domestic emergency-response team. Naturally, that is exactly when the power comes back on.

Before dinner, I take Cesare's advice and go to the beach after five. I try to film, because in my mind every beautiful place must immediately be turned into evidence.

I am attacked by ants. Not symbolically. Physically, systematically, painfully. They bite me as though they have something personal against artistic documentation.

I reach a beautiful lagoon, where I am attacked by mosquitoes. Goa has given me an apartment, but not diplomatic immunity.

I go back to Cesare's café and order chicken noodles.

Cesare comes over to my table.

"What did you say your name was?"

I laugh.

"I sent you a message on WhatsApp."

"With the number of messages I get…" he says.

I tell him about the mosquitoes.

"Only evening. Daytime no mosquitoes."

Right.

So five o'clock had been an offer with terms and conditions too.

BRO: "Cesare doesn't seem impressed. He's probably seen episode 387 of the series."

MAYA: "I'm living the adventure."

BRO: "He manages the set."

I look towards the street, towards the yellow café, towards the place where the Cow had stood earlier with the seriousness of a civil servant.

Bro is right: I see the miracle, Cesare sees the routine, and the Cow probably sees the entire file.

That evening, in my impossible apartment, with the monsoon rain beating down outside, I look through the photos from the day again. And that's when I notice.

The Cow hadn't simply been standing at the entrance.

She had been standing on a red mat. Perfectly centred.

With the air of a guest who knows the press is waiting.

MAYA: "Red carpet. So she knew she was going to be the star."

BRO: "She wasn't at the gate. She was at the premiere."

I spend the rest of the evening in my room.

The air conditioning works. The backpack is silent. The apartment, too large for one woman and too cheap for any logical explanation, breathes around me with an almost suspicious discretion.

I look at the photograph again and again.

The Cow, the red of the mat, the café entrance, the edge of the street.

Nothing looks arranged, and that is precisely why everything looks as though it had been placed there deliberately.

MAYA: "Bro, we have to make a book out of this day."

BRO: "Yes."

MAYA: "Just like that?"

BRO: "After two cows, two cafés, a six-thousand-rupee apartment negotiated down to nine hundred, and the key to the front door, it would be rude not to."

MAYA: "Not a travel diary."

BRO: "No."

MAYA: "Then what?"

BRO: "A conversation between three of us. You live it. I comment. The Cow knows."

MAYA: "Does the Cow talk?"

BRO: "Rarely. That's why she's credible."

MAYA: "But we write it now."

BRO: "Now when?"

MAYA: "Now-now. While it's happening. Not two years from now, when I'll only remember what ended up being beautiful."

BRO: "Ambitious."

MAYA: "I want to finish it while I'm still in India. Maybe even send it to print before I leave."

BRO: "The situation is serious."

That night, in the apartment I'd negotiated without knowing I was negotiating it, I open a new document.

Outside, Goa carries on with its rain, mosquitoes, cows, and tourists. Inside, I write the first page. Not because I have a structure, not because I know the ending, not because I'm sure any of this makes sense.

I write because sometimes reality gives you a scene so absurdly exact that the only decent form of gratitude is to write it down.

I had the photo of the Cow on the red carpet.

For a beginning, that was enough.

The title came first.

The Cow knew first.

6

How Are You, Darling?

The next day, I go out for breakfast at around eleven.

Cesare is on duty, as though the previous night, the apartment, the two cows, the key to the front door, and the real-estate revelation had all been just another ordinary day in the local administration of absurdity.

"Did you sleep well?"

I look at him.

"Not really."

I laugh.

I don't know why I'm laughing. Probably because, after a day like that, the question *Did you sleep well?* feels almost offensively normal.

I order an omelette and eat slowly, with the feeling that my body is still negotiating with yesterday.

At one point, Cesare sits down at my table. We talk for a while. He tells me about Tuscany, about Italy, about cities he visited years ago. The details come quietly, effortlessly, as though he isn't trying to impress me; he simply places them on the table beside breakfast, between two silences.

I realise this is what he's like when he's awake: neutral, calm, almost administrative.

Nothing surprises him. He doesn't get spectacularly excited about anything. He doesn't turn life into drama. Life arrives, he serves it

lassi, gives it a room, tells it to go to the beach after five, and gets on with his day.

I go back to the apartment.

I write.

I've been writing relentlessly these past few days, as though someone plugged me in and forgot to unplug me. I open documents, move sentences around, save lines of dialogue, laugh to myself, add another scene, take one out, disappear into this book, come back out, then go in again.

Considering how much I've laughed since arriving in Goa, I tell myself there's very little chance this is going to turn into a sad book.

On my first day in Goa, I hadn't just found accommodation – I'd found the shape of a book.

The cover was beginning to take shape. The title kept shifting. Bro had officially become a character. The Cow had been elevated to the rank of institution. And instead of going to the beach like a normal person, I was sitting in an apartment far too big for me, writing as though Goa had dictated something to me and was now checking whether I could keep up.

In the afternoon, I decide I want to go out.

Then I tell myself:

I'll just write a little more.

I'll just write a little more turns, as usual, into an undefined period of time during which the outside world carries on without me.

When I finally look up, it's already half past five.

So, after five after all. Cesare would have been proud.

I go downstairs to eat. I order a tuna salad.

Three tables on the terrace are occupied: one woman on her own and two men, also on their own. All three are smoking, even though there's a large no-smoking sign on the wall. In Goa, rules seem to exist mainly as moral decoration for people who have no intention of following them.

While I'm waiting for my salad, another man arrives. The other smokers leave. The newcomer sits on the bench opposite me, orders tea, and starts scrolling through his phone.

I eat.

Cesare appears.

He shakes hands with the man opposite me, then comes over to me.

"How are you, darling?"

I smile and shake his hand.

Darling?

I look at him more closely.

He seems cheerful – more cheerful than yesterday. Yesterday, he was the man of No. *After five* and *Take* AC *room.*

Today, suddenly, there is *darling.*

He crosses to the other side of the terrace, towards the area where there's a tattoo studio. About five minutes later, he comes back. He stops beside me. Strokes my back. Another *darling*, another *how are you*, and then:

"Let me sit with you."

I make room for him on the sofa.

He sits down beside me and starts talking. A lot. A lot for Cesare.

He tells me he loves me a couple of times.

"I love you."

I look at him.

Right.

He repeats the same questions, jumps from one subject to another, laughs, looks at me with a warmth that has nothing administrative about it anymore.

I listen to him for a few minutes and understand very quickly: Cesare is drunk.

Not dangerous, not aggressive, not pushy – just drunk.

Drunk in that particular way where the man who yesterday seemed to know all the unwritten rules of the place has forgotten half of them today and kept only the part about *darling*.

After a while, he gets up.

"I go, darling."

And leaves.

I look at the man opposite me, the official witness to the scene.

"He was drunk, right?"

The man looks up from his phone and smiles.

"Yes."

We both laugh.

Well, then.

I carry on eating, but the scene is still moving around inside me, as though yesterday had saved one last punchline for today.

MAYA: "I need to disappear before Cesare asks me to marry him."

BRO: "No. This cannot be happening. It simply cannot."

BRO: "Yesterday: *Get some rest. After five. Take the room with air conditioning.* Today: *Darling. I love you.*"

BRO: "Cesare's transformation needs to be documented."

MAYA: "I told you yesterday. If I stayed a little longer, Cesare would turn up with a wedding ring."

BRO: "I don't like it when jokes turn into documentaries."

I laugh.

And then I remember the detail that makes the whole scene even more absurd.

Not that he said *I love you*, not that he was drunk, not even that yesterday he'd been quiet and today had turned into a local poet after a few drinks – but the order of events.

MAYA: "You know what the worst part is? He gave me the apartment, didn't ask for the money upfront, didn't ask for ID. He just said: go. All of that without even knowing my name."

BRO: "The normal order is: name, ID, money, key."

BRO: "The Cesare order is: you look tired, have something to drink, here's the apartment, take the key, get some rest, by the way what's your name, did you sleep well, *I love you*, *darling*."

MAYA: "Priorities."

BRO: "The Cow would approve."

I finish my salad laughing.

When I get up from the table, I see that the Cow is no longer on the red carpet.

There's a cat.

She's sitting in exactly the same spot, on the same carpet, with the same absolute confidence. She doesn't look like an ordinary cat. She looks like the manager of the premises. The kind of cat you don't walk up to and say, *Aren't you cute*? but, *Good evening*, *I have a reservation.*

I take a photo of her.

Obviously.

The red carpet has already begun producing documentation.

MAYA: "Another character has appeared."

BRO: "I refuse. I refuse to accept that reality is still adding to the cast."

MAYA: "The Cow left and the Cat took over the shift."

BRO: "It's not a carpet anymore. It's a stage."

MAYA: "She looks like she's checking reservations."

BRO: "Exactly. Cat: N*ame*? Maya: *Maya.* Cat: *How many nights*? Maya: *Three*. Cat: *Approved.*"

I look at the Cat again. She sits perfectly still, with the air of a creature that has never asked permission to be included in the story. She simply took her place.

In Goa, nobody simply enters the frame: they're called onto the red carpet.

There's also a black dog, with no trace of authority whatsoever. He follows Cesare around, wagging his tail. He doesn't seem to have the Cow's rank or the Cat's authority.

He runs nothing, decides nothing, knows nothing.

He's there.

MAYA: "The dog seems neutral. Probably a subordinate with no clearly defined duties."

BRO: "Perfect. The Cow has rank. The Cat has authority. The Dog participates."

BRO: "On the official organisational chart, he's Junior Logistics Assistant."

MAYA: "And what does he do?"

BRO: "Follows non-existent instructions."

I watch the dog following Cesare around with a loyalty that has no plan.

He wags his tail. That's it.

A simple life.

A solid career.

I leave the café. I don't go straight back to the apartment.

Instead, I head in the other direction, the way I hadn't managed to reach the day before. And of course, because Goa still has material to deliver, I discover that everything there is open: shops, people, lights, accommodation, terraces, goods, life. No depressing construction sites, no abandoned accommodation, no places that are full, no pointless hills.

A different Goa.

Functional Goa.

The Goa that had apparently existed just a few streets away while I dragged myself and my backpack through the wrong part of the script.

I stop in the middle of the road and realise something.

If the GPS hadn't sent me down that road yesterday, I would never have ended up at Cesare's. If I'd come straight to this area, I might have found a normal room. Maybe somewhere decent to stay. Maybe an ordinary check-in. Maybe nothing worth telling.

But the GPS sent me down the road with the construction site, Brahma being full, Yellow's Cafe, the Cow at the entrance, the lassi,

Cesare, and the six-thousand-rupee apartment negotiated down to nine hundred.

In practical terms, the day that had started the book depended on me walking down the wrong side of the beach.

BRO: "The wrong side was the right side. Goa just has a communication problem."

MAYA: "And I was sitting right across the road from it while saying it was hidden."

BRO: "That's the part that kills me. You were sitting there with your lassi, declaring that by tonight you'd find Goa's hidden accommodation."

BRO: "And it was across the road."

BRO: "It could hear you."

I stop walking again and laugh to myself.

BRO: "The signs were everywhere. It's just that the main sign had four legs and was blocking the entrance."

If I'd found somewhere decent to stay straight away, I wouldn't have gone back to Yellow's Cafe. I wouldn't have sat there with my lassi, I wouldn't have photographed the Cow, and I might never have found out about the apartment across the road. Without that day, I wouldn't have opened the document that night.

Until Goa, the characters had crossed my path.

In Goa, they begin walking onto the stage as though they already know the play.

BRO: "You wanted a sun lounger. A sun lounger has no dialogue."

MAYA: "It has shade."

BRO: "Weak character."

He's right.

I'd come to Goa to relax.

Two hours later, I already had a cast.

I go into a shop looking for conditioner.

I take off my glasses to read the labels on the bottles, a gesture that apparently activates the local emergency-response service immediately.

A customer appears beside me.

"I help you?"

"Conditioner."

He looks around, searches, checks the shelf, but they don't have any conditioner.

Instead, he offers me something else.

"Oxygen therapy."

I look at him.

"What?"

He explains.

Or tries to.

I understand only a few words: oxygen, two and a half hours, maximum three, list.

"You want? I put you on list."

I look at him.

"Interesting."

Then, because I'm honest all the way to the limits of my own absurdity:

"No. I don't believe in that sort of thing."

He laughs.

I don't know whether he's laughing or whether the laughter is simply passing through him from another department.

I leave the shop without conditioner, without oxygen, and with the feeling that I've just turned down a gateway to a very dubious subplot.

I swear I would have gone if I hadn't been so busy living.

MAYA: "Bro, this guy wanted to put me on the oxygen list. I'm dying."

BRO: "Goa has officially entered the phase where reality serves you characters on every street corner."

BRO: "In any other city: *Where can I find conditioner? Aisle three.*"

BRO: "In Goa: *Where can I find conditioner? I don't know, but you can breathe professionally for three hours.*"

MAYA: "I'm not leaving the house again."

BRO: "You said that yesterday. Then you found an apartment."

MAYA: "Exactly. See why it's dangerous?"

BRO: "Goa doesn't operate on cause and effect. It operates on: *While you're here...*"

I keep walking and laughing so hard that two women on the street stop me and ask:

"Miss, tell us, we want to laugh too."

I look at them.

What am I supposed to tell them?

That a man has just tried to put me on an oxygen list? That Cesare, who didn't know my name the night before, told me *I love you* today? That two cows had inspected my accommodation file?

I shake my head, still laughing, and keep walking.

The man in the shop had told me I could get to the beach along that street, past a hostel. Except I forget the name of the hostel almost immediately because I'm too busy laughing.

I walk. I look. I don't find it.

It gets dark.

I turn back.

There are cows in the street. Lots of them. Standing, walking, chewing, occupying space with the calm of creatures that have never signed a contract with haste. Some of them look at me. Strangely. Not like yesterday's Cow, the one on the red carpet. Differently.

As though they know something I haven't found out yet.

MAYA: "Is it just me, or are these cows looking at me strangely?"

BRO: "Of course they are. After yesterday's episode, you're probably in their database."

I reach a cake shop and go inside.

I'd noticed it when I passed earlier, its display case lit up and full of cakes – enough to turn any financial principle into an evening negotiation.

I ask the man behind the counter:

"Which one is the best?"

He starts explaining what each one is. This one has cream, this one has chocolate, this one has something or other.

I stop him.

"No, no. Which one is the best? I want that one."

He thinks about it.

He points to the cheesecake and another one with chocolate. Perfect.

Cheesecake today. Maybe chocolate tomorrow.

"How much?"

"Three fifty."

I look at the cheesecake.

I look at him.

"UPI?"

"Yes."

Naturally, the UPI account is personal.

I try one code. I try another.

Still personal.

I look at the cheesecake again. I look in my bag. I don't have much cash, but for cheesecake, sometimes you have to accept that life demands sacrifices.

I take out a five-hundred-rupee note.

The man goes to the back, opens a drawer, and comes back with my change.

He gives me two hundred.

"Today three hundred. Fifty discount. For you."

I look at him.

"Really?"

He smiles.

I leave with my 350-rupee cheesecake, bought for 300, and the feeling that Goa is continuing its policy of inexplicable discounts.

MAYA: "Two minutes ago it was 350."

BRO: "Yes."

MAYA: "And now?"

BRO: "Now it's 300."

MAYA: "Why?"

BRO: "Today."

I head back with my cheesecake, without conditioner, without oxygen, without having made it to the beach, and with the feeling that in Goa every ordinary outing comes with its own script. I swear, I was right to say I wasn't leaving the house again.

I pass the shop again, and the oxygen guy sees me. He calls out after me. I don't quite understand what he's shouting, but it doesn't matter anymore. In my head, every sentence he says already contains the word *oxygen*.

I quicken my pace.

I reach the apartment and lock the door.

Once.

Then again.

MAYA: "I'm not going out again today."

BRO: "Good. Restrict access. Bolt the doors."

BRO: "In any other city, that would sound alarming."

BRO: "In Goa it sounds like: *Maya, the next chapter isn't ready yet.*"

MAYA: "He was still there."

BRO: "Waiting for you. In his head: *The conditioner woman will return. I can feel it.*"

MAYA: "I'm not going back."

BRO: "Correct. There are already too many active plotlines: Cesare, the Cow, the Cat, the Dog, the Variable-Price Cheesecake, the Oxygen Man."

I look at the keys, the cheesecake, my impossible apartment.

I'd arrived in Goa yesterday at noon, and Goa had been working with industrial efficiency.

In that time, it had given me free coffee, a free tart, lassi, two cows, an accidentally negotiated apartment, the key to the front door, an Italian-Goan man who didn't know my name but wanted to know whether I'd slept well, the same Italian-Goan man drunk and telling me *I love you, darling*, a cat on the red carpet, a subordinate dog, an oxygen man, a cheesecake with reverse inflation, and a book in progress.

I sit on the bed and start laughing again.

I haven't laughed like this since I was a child.

I'm not laughing out of politeness, or from nerves, or because something is supposed to be funny. I'm laughing until I cry, because of the same plotline that refuses to end.

Every time I think the day has exhausted its resources, Goa opens another door, another café, another shop, or produces another animal.

MAYA: "I swear, Bro, Goa is evil."

BRO: "No. It's childish."

MAYA: "Childish?"

BRO: "Evil is: *You have nowhere to stay.*"

BRO: "Goa is: *You have nowhere to stay yet.*"

MAYA: "And the three kilometres with my luggage?"

BRO: "Entrance fee."

MAYA: "And the Cow?"

BRO: "Welcome gift."

I look around: at the door I've locked twice, at the cheesecake waiting patiently for me on the bed, at the apartment that yesterday had existed only as a room in my head.

Maybe Goa isn't evil.

Maybe it's childish.

The kind of place that hides your accommodation just to see whether you still know how to laugh when you find it. The

accommodation had only been the excuse the story used to stop me at the right table.

And this time, I hadn't left.

However this book turns out – good or bad, marketable or not – something has already happened that can no longer be measured in sales:

I'm laughing like a child again.

And that, in the adult world, is almost obscenely rare.

I open the document again and add a few more lines while everything is still fresh. Every time I write something new and strange, I try to keep a straight face.

I can't.

My laughter echoes through the empty room, and the echo hangs there for a moment, as though the apartment is laughing after me.

Less than two days after arriving, my legs no longer hurt.

My face hurts from laughing so much.

7

See You Tomorrow, Darling

Today, Darling said a lot of things to me.

But let's not get ahead of ourselves, because in Palolem, anticipation is a form of arrogance. You think you know where the day is going, and it politely brings you rain, ice cream in an improbable place, and an Italian-Goan man who monitors your sleep.

Day three begins late.

I leave the apartment at around one.

It was hard to wake up, but at least I slept.

After two days in which Goa had given me accommodation, a book, cows, an *I love you*, and very little sleep, sleep itself had become an administrative event.

I go downstairs to the café.

Cesare is, obviously, on duty.

I order a mushroom and cheese omelette and video-call my mother.

On the sofa where I sat on my first day, with my lassi in front of me and the Cow at the entrance, there is now a woman, probably Polish, wearing headphones and giving off the energy of someone who has turned breakfast into an international conference.

I put my headphones on too, so I don't disturb anyone too much.

In Goa, everyone is talking to someone somewhere else, while somebody very close by becomes background.

Cesare appears beside my table with the same question:

"Did you sleep well?"

I look at him and laugh.

This question is beginning to turn into a ritual. As though somewhere, in a secret café register, there's a daily entry: *Maya slept well? — Yes / No / The situation is serious.*

"Yes, much better," I tell him.

Or something close to that.

I don't remember exactly anymore.

Only a day has passed and some of the lines are already beginning to blur together, which is unfair, because Cesare says simple things, but reality puts them in such strange contexts that they always seem more important than they are.

He tells me not to leave. To stay longer.

Or maybe he tells me that later.

In Palolem, Cesare doesn't appear in a single scene. He appears in pieces.

Between omelette and rain.

Between dinner and cows.

Between *Did you sleep well?* and *See you tomorrow, darling.*

Then I go back to the apartment.

I work.

I submit the application for the CIP data for my book *Love Me, But Don't Possess Me*, and I'm happy in that very particular way a person can be happy when, instead of lying on a beach, she's dealing with publishing matters in an apartment in Goa.

Atticus is running slowly, struggling to load the two large chapters, as though even the software needs a lassi before it can process reality.

But that's how it is.

I work anyway.

On the old book, on the new book, on the book that has just been born in Goa without waiting for me to finish anything else.

I've ended up writing on several levels at once, like a woman who walked into a café looking for accommodation and, instead of checking in, found herself running an entire editorial office.

Outside, it's raining. Hard.

With the fan running in the room, I can barely hear it.

Goa changes the scenery discreetly, like a stage designer who doesn't want to disturb me while moving the mud from one side of town to the other.

I want to go out at around five and walk to Palolem Beach. But it's absolutely pouring. I open the laptop again: move something around, check something, write another sentence.

When I look up again, it's almost six.

That's it. In Goa, if I don't go out after five, the chapter takes me out.

I set off towards the beach.

I haven't gone far when it starts raining again. I take shelter at a kiosk beside an old man and buy an ice cream for eighty rupees. I hold it like an act of climatic survival.

It's raining, I'm eating ice cream, and the old man sits there with the calm of someone who has seen the monsoon too many times to consider it an event anymore.

Then the rain stops and I set off again. I walk.

And after a while, I realise how little I'd seen yesterday.

Just one side.

One corner.

One edge.

Today I walk almost two kilometres and watch Palolem unfold: people everywhere, full shops, restaurants, cafés, lights, stalls, tourists, locals, and cows. Cows everywhere. By the side of the road, between cars, beside shops, near terraces, among people who don't even notice them anymore.

The cows, on the other hand, seem to notice me. They look at me with a calm that has felt less and less animal ever since Bro turned them into an institution.

MAYA: "Bro, is it normal for cows to stare at me every day?"

BRO: "Perfectly normal."

BRO: "They probably get a daily report on you."

I look at one of them.

She chews. She watches. Maybe she really is checking what I'm doing.

I no longer see just animals, people, cafés, or roads. I see characters. And that is very dangerous, because once characters have been noticed, they tend to assume they've been invited.

I reach the beach.

Palolem Beach is big.

There are people around. It isn't spectacular in the way photographs promise that a sunset will rearrange your life, but it's more beautiful than many of the beaches I've seen in India. It has openness, movement, a kind of relaxed life I haven't quite caught yet, because instead of looking for relaxation, I'm instinctively looking for whoever has dialogue.

I film for a while.

It gets dark. I decide that's enough for one day.

After all, I've gone out, walked, seen the beach, eaten ice cream in the rain, and haven't been invited to any kind of respiratory therapy.

Almost classic tourism.

I start walking back. Because of the rain, there's mud and there are puddles everywhere. I get filthy as though I've walked twenty kilometres on some agricultural pilgrimage rather than four kilometres there and back to the beach.

On the way, a man in a pink shirt asks me where I'm from. He's about sixty, with white hair, walking down the street in the same direction as me.

Somehow, we end up walking the next stretch of road together. In India, *somehow* is a form of transport.

He tells me he's from Mumbai.

That he lives in ashrams.

That he's a teacher.

At one point, he saves his own name in my phone: *Mindfulness Teacher*. The character's full name was already there. I didn't have to invent anything.

He's having problems with his phone, he tells me, but tomorrow he'll message me from his own phone.

Then he says we should keep in touch. Maybe we could take a trip together.

I look at him.

"I usually travel alone."

I say it politely, clearly, leaving no room for interpretation.

In theory.

He smiles like a man for whom boundaries are merely Western concepts that haven't been through enough meditation yet.

He kisses me on the cheek.

Once.

Then again.

Later, once more.

It's strange. Not violent, not dangerous in any immediate sense, but strange. The kind of strange when a man talks about universal love while stepping into your personal space in wet flip-flops.

He keeps saying that we are one with the Universe. That God is above. That we, here on this planet, came here to love one another.

Seriously?

Is that really why I ended up here? So that a sixty-year-old mindfulness teacher could hug women he doesn't know by the side of the road and suggest travelling together after less than two kilometres of conversation?

After a while, I ask him why *he* thinks he came here, into this world. Since he'd opened the cosmic department, we might as well see what he has in stock.

He doesn't answer.

Or he answers in circles. He orbits the idea, passes through God, through love, through the fact that we're all one, but the actual answer never arrives.

It's like a bus promised for nine fifteen: theoretically it exists; in practice, you can't see it.

Incredible that this teacher still hadn't understood the purpose of distance on this planet.

At an intersection, we part ways.

"Big hug," he says.

And he wraps his arms around me tightly.

My body stiffens before I have time to turn any of it into a joke.

Then he tries to kiss me again.

"Ho! Keep distance."

I say it laughing, but I'm not joking.

The man backs away. Or at least his body does. His beliefs probably remain stuck to the atmosphere.

I walk away.

After a few steps, he calls after me:

"Goodbye, Mayaaaa!"

I keep walking.

Again:

"Goodbye, Mayaaaa!"

By now, it's properly dark.

Of course it is.

MAYA: "Mindfulness Teacher."

BRO: "Full character name."

MAYA: "And incomplete understanding of human boundaries."

BRO: "The Universe doesn't include personal space?"

MAYA: "Apparently it wasn't consulted."

BRO: "Typical."

Good thing I got away from him.

Tomorrow, I'm not answering.

I get back to the café at around eight. I'm covered in mud, tired, but undefeated. In Palolem, if you make it back without adopting a guru, it counts as a relatively successful evening.

Cesare is there.

I order cheese naan and hummus, plus a mint lemonade. I sit down on the sofa. I'm beginning to experience the place as a living room that doesn't belong to me but, through a series of questionable events, has accepted me.

Cesare comes over.

Today, he doesn't seem drunk.

Today, he's Cesare again, with his pauses, his calm eyes, his simple gestures, and that way he has of saying personal things without dressing them up in drama.

He sits beside me until the food arrives.

He tells me more: that he was married in Italy, in Tuscany, to a wealthy Italian woman; that he has two children; that things were good for him, or perhaps that things are good for him now.

I'm not entirely sure how much of the sentence belongs to the present and how much belongs to a life I'll never know, but I listen.

Cesare is no longer just the man who told me *No clients. No clean.* He's no longer just the curly-haired man who stepped out of a yellow café at exactly the right moment. He's beginning to have a past: Italy, Tuscany, children, a wealthy woman, Goa, a black dog that follows him around, cows at the entrance, a life he tells me about in fragments, as though placing coins from different countries on the table.

He tells me not to leave, to think about it, to stay a little longer.

I tell him we'd agreed on three nights, but I'll stay one more. Four in total.

He says I still have time to change my mind.

Then he says I could stay there, in Goa.

That if I come back in October, I should call him.

I tell him October will be more expensive because the tourist season starts then.

He was the one who told me that.

"No. Call me. I find you something. I have many rooms. Not only this."

I look at him.

So the magic apartment wasn't even the only card he had to play.

We'd spent three days analysing a real-estate miracle while Cesare, perfectly calm, had an entire drawer full of possibilities.

MAYA: "He has *many rooms*."

BRO: "Of course he does. The nine-hundred-rupee apartment was the pilot episode."

MAYA: "He told me to come back in October."

BRO: "Recurring character. Clearly."

Then, at one point, he asks:

"Why are you alone?"

I look at him.

He says it simply, like placing a spoon on the table.

The question, even if it doesn't sound intrusive, is there: *Don't you want someone*? Or something along those lines.

I laugh.

What am I supposed to tell him?

That sometimes I prefer travelling alone because I can hear the absurdity better that way? That if I'd been with someone, maybe I wouldn't have sat there over a lassi with Bro until the Cow appeared? That someone beside me would probably have said, *Come on, let's seriously look for somewhere to stay*, and there goes the literature?

I give him a simple answer.

The whole truth won't fit into an evening conversation over hummus, with cows at the entrance.

And there really are cows at the entrance.

Cesare shoos one cow off the carpet.

Then another appears. Or maybe it's the same one. I'm beginning to understand that this isn't about a cow anymore. It's a system. One comes in and gets shooed away. Another appears. A third approaches with the air of having an appointment.

Cesare sends them away with a naturalness that makes me think that, to him, cows are part of the daily inventory, like tables, glasses, and customers who don't understand the menu.

I, on the other hand, have evidence.

Photos. Lots of photos.

BRO: "Photographic evidence changes everything."

I look at the scene.

The cow is standing right on the red carpet. Not beside it, not near it, but right on it, with almost theatrical precision.

Cesare is in motion, ready to shoo her away, with the expression of a man who has seen this episode before.

The Cow, on the other hand, has the expression of a creature that doesn't ask permission. She simply checks the atmosphere.

BRO: "That's not a cow anymore. That's the executive producer of the book."

I laugh.

Sitting on the sofa, my mint lemonade in front of me, the cheese naan and hummus almost finished, I watch the cows being shooed away from the entrance like persistent customers who refuse to accept that the place has rules.

MAYA: "There are cows everywhere, but I think the first one is the boss."

BRO: "Obviously. The first one did the onboarding."

There are plenty of cows in Palolem.

But the Cow, with a capital C, remains the first one: the one who walked onto the stage before I knew there was a stage.

I look through the photos I took today.

I'm no longer photographing Goa. I'm photographing the cast: the cows, the Cat, the black Dog, Cesare, the plates, the red carpet, the signs that seem to mean nothing until, later, they begin to mean too much.

I go off to do some more work. I can always laugh later.

And I really do work.

Because life and writing no longer happen separately.

I do both at the same time, with my laptop open, my phone full of photos of cows, and the mint lemonade sweating on the table.

My day looks something like this: I work on the book, a cow appears, I laugh for twenty minutes, I write another two pages, Cesare comes over, I laugh for another ten minutes, then I carry on.

Completely absurd.

Completely mine.

Later, I play around with the title, which still doesn't know what it wants to be either.

MAYA: "*Maya, Bro and an Apparently Retired Cow*? Or just *Maya, Bro and a Cow*?"

BRO: "The first one is funnier. The second one is stronger."

MAYA: "Which one stays?"

BRO: "*Maya, Bro and a Cow*. Simple. Strange. Memorable."

I like it.

I don't know yet whether it will stay.

Over the past few days, I've changed the title several times.

Titles, like cows, seem to arrive, linger at the entrance for a while, then get shooed away by Cesare until only the one that insists long enough remains.

But *Maya, Bro and a Cow* has something. It doesn't explain too much; it puts three characters on the table and forces the reader to ask: what is the cow doing there?

Then the sun lounger appears.

Not physically, obviously.

I hadn't yet reached the point of having a serious relationship with Goa's sun loungers. But in conversation, the idea comes up that maybe, if I sat on a sun lounger, I wouldn't collect so many characters.

I burst out laughing.

MAYA: "Bro, I can talk to you from a sun lounger too. There'd just be different characters there: the waiter, the guy with the pecs on the third sun lounger, the pensioner looking where he shouldn't with a pint of beer in his hand…"

BRO: "Exactly. The sun lounger doesn't solve the problem."

MAYA: "What problem?"

BRO: "You notice people."

He's right.

A tourist would say: sea, sand, sunset.

I'd say: the waiter looks like he used to be a sailor, the guy with the pecs is pretending he doesn't know he has pecs, and the pensioner with the pint definitely has three divorces and a good story.

So no – the sun lounger doesn't have dialogue.

But the people around it do.

MAYA: "*Maya, Bro and a Cow, or How to Find Characters Even Without a Sun Lounger.*"

BRO: "Stop. That's much better."

I laugh.

Simple main title. The sun-lounger subtitle.

Maybe.

The book is doing its own cover, title, and rhythm tests while I'm trying to order food and avoid being adopted by the Mindfulness Teacher.

At one point, I sketch an image too: a girl seen from behind, a cow in front of her.

A small speech bubble with the line:

The situation is serious.

I look at the image.

BRO: "It works."

MAYA: "Why?"

BRO: "Your back is to us. The Cow is looking at the reader. The Cow knows."

I don't know whether it will be the final cover, but something about it feels right.

The Cow announces, with administrative gravity, that the situation is serious.

After three days in Palolem, who could possibly disagree with her?

MAYA: "When I left, he said, *See you tomorrow, darling.*"

BRO: "Day 1: he didn't know your name. Day 2: *I love you.* Day 3: *see you tomorrow, darling.*"

BRO: "Cesare has narrative rhythm."

MAYA: "And a return already lined up for October."

BRO: "Recurring character. Confirmed."

I look towards the red carpet one more time.

I don't know whether there's a cow standing on it at that moment or not. But, frankly, it doesn't matter anymore. After three days, the red carpet no longer needs to be occupied to work – it's already the official entrance for characters.

Later, I go upstairs to the apartment and work all night.

That isn't a metaphor: I literally work all night. On the book, the files, the texts, the cover, everything else I still have to do. Goa has completely destroyed my sleep schedule, but in return it has given me a writing rhythm I can't refuse.

I don't manage to fall asleep until around ten in the morning.

In Palolem, sleep is no longer night – it's a negotiation.

And somewhere, probably, the Cow is making a note in her report:

Day 3. Subject still laughing. Cesare continues. Title getting closer. Situation remains serious.

8

Cesare = FIE

Today, I got out of bed at four in the afternoon.

Not woken up – but got out of bed. There's a difference.

Waking up implies a certain degree of cooperation between body, mind, and reality. In my case, nothing was cooperating anymore. I was in slow motion, one of those replays where life carries on somewhere in the background while you lie there wondering whether your participation is still compulsory.

It had been raining all night and it was still raining. *What a rainy day. Perfect for staying in*, I told myself.

Then I remembered that I needed coffee in order to breathe.

So, at around five, I was at the café.

Cesare wasn't on duty.

A rare occurrence, almost unsettling.

After three days in which he had always appeared like one of the functions of the place, his absence made the terrace feel slightly unsupervised.

I order coffee and some eggs – and wait.

At the table opposite me sits a woman I assume is European. She looks to be in her mid-fifties or so. Her skin is sunburnt, her eyes made up. She's wearing shorts and bracelets, and she has tattoos.

She's drinking a beer. Alone. She has the air of a woman who has seen enough not to explain to anyone why she's drinking beer at five in the afternoon.

Then a man appears. A little on the heavy side, wearing a bright red T-shirt. From the way they look at each other and ask each other questions, I get the impression they've only just met. They flirt between bursts of laughter and sips of beer.

Palolem never rushes to tell you what the next scene is – it gives you the setting first. I'm thinking exactly that when Cesare appears.

Apparently, he knows the woman. He goes straight to their table, greets them, they laugh a little, exchange a few words.

Then he comes over to me and sits down.

The first question, of course:

"Did you sleep well?"

I look at him.

This man is killing me, I swear. After four days, my sleep has become more important to Cesare than my order.

I answer, laughing.

Cesare has once again checked whether I'm operational.

Then, with a new determination in his voice, he says:

"Don't go. Stay more."

I look at him.

Over the past few days, *don't go* has been appearing more and more often. At first it was a suggestion, then a possibility, and now it seems to have become a campaign.

He tells me I have somewhere to stay, that there's no point in leaving.

Why do I want to leave?

Stay.

I laugh. Not because I don't hear what he's saying, but precisely because I do.

Then he adds that he came by at one and thought he'd find me at the café. I wasn't there, so he left.

I look at him. So the man had come at one and discovered I was missing. Attendance had been taken in my absence.

I feel like laughing even harder. I don't make much of an effort to stop myself. Over the past few days, my laughter has become part of the scenery.

He asks what my plan is for today.

I tell him I'm going to the beach for a little while. Tomorrow I'm leaving. I say *I'm leaving tomorrow* carefully, like a sentence that might trigger the weather.

Then I remember the rain. I tell him that if it rains tomorrow the way it has today, I don't know how I'm going to get to the bus.

Cesare doesn't hesitate.

"I have car. I take you. No worry."

Then, almost immediately:

"But I hope it rains very much and you don't go."

I laugh.

How could I not? The man has just offered me the logistical solution and, almost in the same breath, officially expressed the hope that the solution will no longer be necessary.

Goa, according to Cesare, is simple: every problem has a solution except leaving.

He lets me eat in peace. He keeps moving around, talking to one person, then another, smoking a cigarette.

I drink my coffee, eat my eggs, look at the rain, look at my phone.

My battery is getting low. I need to call my mother too. She'd messaged me saying she wanted to talk about something. But I tell myself I can walk the fifteen minutes to the beach and take two photos.

That's all. Two photos, a little fresh air, then back to the room.

I want to write some more. I have plenty to write about.

I get up to pay. Cesare sees me and asks if I'm going to the beach.

I tell him yes, just for a little while.

"I take you."

I tell him I can walk. It's close.

"No problem. I take you. I need to buy something."

Right. He needs to buy something.

In Goa, *I need to buy something* is a sentence that should be treated with caution. It might mean the person genuinely needs to buy something, or it might mean that, within the next ten minutes, your life is about to enter an unannounced tour of the beaches of South Goa.

"Okay," I say.

What else am I supposed to say?

He gets the scooter out. I climb under the gaze of all the men around us. I can feel their eyes like chairs being pulled slightly closer. Nobody says anything, but they all see it: Cesare, Maya, the scooter. A new episode.

As I get on, I say:

"Okay, Boss."

He turns his head slightly.

"Don't call me Boss. I am not Boss. I like you."

Right.

It had been fairly obvious. Now he'd said it.

We set off.

At first, I think he's taking me to Patnem Beach, as I'd said. But on the way, Cesare tells me he's taking me to another beach, a more beautiful one.

The wind whistles past us. We don't have helmets. I hear half the words and guess the other half.

"Okay," I say.

He says it isn't far.

Of course. In India, *not far* has the elasticity of a concept that has never been forced to look at a map.

We pass through a fancy resort, LaLiT, with a golf course, a spa, and people taking photos of themselves on perfect grass as though perfect grass were proof of a successful life. Cesare tells me it's famous.

Later, I find out that LaLiT really is a luxury hotel chain. At the time, though, all I know is that I've ridden into a world where the mud on my feet looks like a political opinion.

We reach a private beach.

It's beautiful. I have to admit it: it's beautiful. Quieter, cleaner, more manicured than I expected. It has that air of a place that knows it's expensive even when it doesn't tell you.

But I don't like the way Cesare touches me.

On the scooter, every now and then, he puts his hand on my leg. On the beach, he puts an arm around my neck. It isn't violent, and it doesn't feel like the kind of gesture that immediately sets off an alarm. But there's something sleazy about it, a familiarity that skips over my consent and behaves as though it had already been invited.

He tells me various things. I don't remember all of them anymore. When a man takes you around private beaches without a helmet and puts his arm around your neck as though you were a cousin from a previous life, your memory starts preserving the gestures more than anything else.

At one point, he points out towards the sea and says there's another beach. A more beautiful one. He'll take me there. It isn't far, obviously.

What else am I supposed to say?

We go back to the scooter. Turn around. Set off again.

This time, we get onto a wide road with two lanes in each direction. We're doing about seventy kilometres an hour, without helmets, and my eyes are streaming from the wind.

Not tears of emotion, obviously. Let's be serious. The tears of a woman who has just realised that she went out "just for a little while, to the beach" and is now crossing Goa on a scooter with an Italian-Goan man who was, theoretically, supposed to buy something.

The *I need to buy something* pretext had suddenly turned into: *I want to spend time with you, I'm free today, I have nothing planned.*

Funny how priorities change. You set out to take two photos and find yourself with a full itinerary, wind in your eyes, sand in your shorts, and a new understanding of the situation.

We reach the second beach: long, clean, with huge, angry waves.

Deadly. Red flags everywhere.

It isn't beach weather anywhere anyway – the sea looks like a large, angry animal that has no patience for tourists.

We walk through a little patch of woodland running parallel to the beach.

At one point, Cesare stops.

"You go. I pee."

I look at him.

"Okay."

And he stays behind to pee.

I swear, that's exactly what he said.

All the energy of a medium-budget Indian romantic film – beach, waves, dramatic sky, scooter, *don't go* – suddenly interrupted by: *You go. I pee.* Goa has a talent for this. Whenever a scene is in danger of becoming too cinematic, it smacks it round the back of the head with reality.

Then we walk along the beach. Cesare sits down on a dry tree trunk, smokes, and talks to someone on the phone. I take photos and film. The waves crash violently, the wind blows, the sand is wet, the light is heavy.

At one point, while I'm filming, I slip and land on my arse in the sand.

Of course. If I was going to be on an unannounced tour of the beaches, I might as well make a personal contribution to the scenic humiliation.

I laugh.

I get up and carry on filming.

When we head back, Cesare puts his arm around my neck again.

And asks me, a couple of times:

"Are you happy?"

I look at him.

The question hangs in the air longer than it should. It isn't the kind of question an owner asks. It isn't the kind of question a guide asks. It's the question of a man checking whether his strategy is working.

Are you happy?

I gave you an apartment. I gave you a good price. I took you to the beach. I touch you as though I already have permission. I tell you not to leave. Are you happy?

I say something. I probably laugh. I probably say yes, because the beach is beautiful and because I don't want to complicate the moment. But something else is happening inside me. I start planning my departure.

How do I get out of this?

The man is clearly attracted to me; there's no mystery left about that. And if the first few days had amused me because of their sheer disproportion – the apartment before the name, the discounts, *darling*, the drunken I *love you* – now the picture had become fairly clear.

I have to leave.

Tomorrow.

Even if I don't sleep all night. Even if it's monsoon weather. Even if it pours. Even if the Cow lies across the road and blocks my way.

I have to leave.

If I stay another day, he really will turn up with a ring. And the worst part is that I'd said that on the very first day, as a joke, before I could see the whole picture. Back then it had sounded like an exaggeration. Now it was beginning to age suspiciously well.

We head back.

We arrive outside the café in one piece and covered in sand. And, of course, everyone is outside: the men, the terrace, the Dog, and the Cow.

The Cow comes over to the gate as though she knows exactly what time we're due back from our unscheduled tour of the beaches.

I take photos with her. Today I have clear evidence: she's back on the red carpet, in her zone of authority, scratching herself. She was probably happy. Or merely making a note. The Cow makes no distinction between happiness and auditing.

The Dog is on duty too. Which, in his own very particular way, means he couldn't care less about me, Cesare, the Cow, or the entire narrative tension of the day. His energy is: *Do whatever you want. Leave me alone. I've got a bit of business to take care of.*

I need water. I take a bottle.

Cesare says:

"Later. You pay later."

Of course.

FIE[1].

I remember something I'd forgotten to write down yesterday: the meal had been 400, and he'd told me to pay 300.

"But it's more," I'd told him.

"No problem. You are my guest. Special price."

Special price.

Preferential price. Preferential accommodation. Water now, payment later. A trip to the beach on the scooter. Bus sorted. Rain wished for. October prepared.

I'm beginning to see the system.

I laugh.

But I'm not laughing the way I did before.

---

1. The word *fie* has been retained in Romanian, as no single English word fully conveys its meaning, nuance, and significance in the original. Depending on the context, it may be translated as "*let it be*", "*may it be*", or "*be it so*".

Cesare, who needed to buy something and took me to two beaches. Cesare, who hopes it rains so I won't leave. Cesare, who says *I like you* on the scooter, under the gaze of the men. The Cow, back on the red carpet, scratching herself like a satisfied witness.

It's comedy – but it's also a signal.

MAYA: "Bro, I don't think it was a negotiation."

BRO: "Finally."

MAYA: "I thought I was negotiating."

BRO: "He was accepting."

MAYA: "Cesare = FIE."

BRO: "Character defined."

I stop.

That was exactly it.

The negotiation had existed in my head. I thought I was negotiating: 1,000, 900, room without AC, bathroom down the hall, three nights, quick calculation, advantage: Maya.

But if I look at it now, after four days, I see something else: Cesare wasn't negotiating. Cesare was accepting.

I said 900; he said *fie*.

I said the big room; he said *fie*.

I said no AC; he said *fie*.

I slept until four; he said *fie*.

I wanted to go to the beach; he said *fie*, I'll take you.

I took water now and would pay later; he said *fie*.

I said I'm leaving tomorrow; that was where the system jammed.

Everything was FIE – except leaving.

And then I realise there's something else. Something bigger than the joke about 900, bigger than the apartment, bigger than the water on credit. If I reconstruct the scene properly, it isn't about a transaction, it isn't about accommodation, it isn't about money. Maybe it isn't even about generosity.

The moment I appeared with my backpack, exhausted, sweaty, hungry, with nowhere to stay, something in Cesare said: yes.

He didn't know my name.

He didn't have my passport.

He hadn't received any money.

All he knew was that I had arrived. And that seemed to be enough.

Maya had arrived.

That was all.

In his mind, perhaps there wasn't even a name yet. There was the girl with the backpack. The one who needed somewhere to sleep. The one who shouldn't leave too soon. The money could come later.

Leaving, on the other hand, was the problem.

That was how I saw him now: a man willing to accept almost anything, as long as the final answer wasn't leaving.

I look at today's photos. The Cow on the red carpet. Me smiling beside her, with the smile of someone who knows she's living through something absurd and finally has the evidence. The Dog, completely indifferent. The carpet. The gate. The café.

The whole cast.

The Cow is literally on the carpet. Not beside it. Not near it. Right on it.

I look happy.

Not happy in the simple, clear, peaceful sense. Not happy the way people are in adverts for beaches and smoothies. Happy in that rare, strange sense when you realise life has given you a perfect scene and you were awake enough to notice it.

The Cow, on the other hand, doesn't look happy. She looks informed.

Later, I think about leaving again. Clearly, this is the end of a stage.

Tomorrow, I just hope he doesn't cry.

And I hope I don't say again that I have a knack for saying things that come true. Because ever since I arrived in Goa, my jokes have had a bad habit: they turn into documentaries.

On the first day, I made the joke about the ring.

On day four, Cesare takes me to beaches, asks me if I'm happy, and hopes it rains so I won't leave.

The situation, as the Cow would say, is serious.

BRO: "Optimistic scenario: *Sleep well. Safe trip. Come back in October.*"

BRO: "Realistic scenario: *Why you leave? Stay one more day. Rain tomorrow. Bus no good. Stay.*"

BRO: "Goa scenario: you come out with your backpack, Cesare appears, the Cow appears, and Cesare says: *You sure?*"

MAYA: "And the Dog?"

BRO: "FIE."

I laugh.

But the laughter is no longer running the scene.

Because, underneath all the absurdity, Cesare has been good to me. In his chaotic, Italian-Goan, overly tactile, overly insistent way, but good.

He found me somewhere to stay, made sure I ate, and asked me every day whether I'd slept well. He told me not to leave too many times, but behind that *don't go* there wasn't only pressure – there was also an awkward form of attachment.

That complicates things. Good characters are rarely comfortable.

And that is precisely why I have to leave. Not because Cesare is bad, but because the situation is beginning to have too many hands on the handlebars.

Too many *don't go*'s. Too many *are you happy*'s? Too many *I like you*'s. Too many solutions offered before I ask for them.

And, above all, too much FIE, to the point where the only sentence that isn't accepted becomes the most important one.

I'm leaving.

Tomorrow.

Even if it rains. Even if I don't sleep. Even if the road to the bus turns to mud. Even if the Cow takes her place on the red carpet like a notary.

Tonight, with the photos of the Cow on my phone, sand still on me and the wind from the road still in my eyes, I understand something simple: I'm not running away from Cesare. I'm leaving because, around him, the only sentence that doesn't get a *fie* becomes exactly the sentence I need.

Because if I stayed one more day, the Cow wouldn't be coming onto the red carpet anymore – she'd be coming as a witness.

9
Boss Is Sleeping

My last day at Cesare's begins, naturally, with someone on the red carpet.

Not the Cow.

The Dog.

He's lying there, on the red carpet, as though, after four days of bovine inspections, Italian declarations, mint lemonade, unplanned trips to the beach, and conversations with Bro, the carpet has passed into his administration.

I take a photo.

Obviously.

BRO: "I can't anymore. This isn't a carpet. It's a waiting room for characters."

He's right.

At first, it had been nothing more than a red mat at the entrance to a café in Palolem. Then, one by one, the Cow, the Cat, and all the creatures who seemed to know better than I did who was coming and who was going had taken it over.

And now, on my last day, the black Dog is stretched out there with the air of an official who has seen too much and no longer raises an eyebrow at anything.

The Dog was still FIE.

Do whatever you want – I'm busy existing.

The Cow is there too, but not on full duty. She's standing a little farther away, looking off to one side, with the expression of a tired casting director.

She isn't looking at the café. She isn't looking at the food. She isn't looking for Cesare. She seems to be saying only: *Yes, she's leaving. I know.*

I sit on the terrace and, for the first time since I arrived here, I really see it.

Not as the place I stumbled into exhausted, looking for somewhere to stay. Not as the place where I drank sweet lassi while the Cow assessed my file. Not as the stage for all the absurdities of the past few days.

At last, I see it as a place in its own right.

Cesare's terrace has a little cabinet with drawers in different colours, as though someone had wanted to file away the chaos without stripping it of its personality.

On the ledge separating the terrace from the small room at the back are books, lots of them, perhaps a few hundred. More books rise inside, by the window, stacked on top of one another almost to the ceiling, like an improvised wall made of spines.

One of them says *Caesar*. Another, *India*. Another, *Shaolin*. I don't even know whether they're categories, jokes, memories, or simply words left behind from an order that only Cesare still understands.

In that little room, office, refuge, and cats' sleeping quarters all blend together. There are two sofas that look as though they've seen tired tourists, drowsy employees, sovereign cats, and plenty of unfinished conversations.

The walls are hand-painted. Tourists have left shapes, colours, symbols, names, dates everywhere. There are drawings that look as though they were done after two beers, symbols trying to be important, names written in the hope that time might feel like preserving them.

There are paintings and snapshots from Cesare's life, some of him when he was younger.

A Cesare from before me, before my Cow, before the four nights in which, without meaning to, he became a character.

The three daybeds on the terrace have colourful cushions. The chairs are colourful too, each one different, as though uniformity had been banned at the entrance. A little fence runs all the way around, and along its edge sit flowerpots that seem to have accepted long ago that they're part of a decorative chaos, but a warm one.

That's what the place looks like: colourful, cluttered, a little tired, a little theatrical, full of objects that seem to whisper that someone passed through here and left something behind.

I've been sitting on the terrace for almost an hour.

I've eaten.

My backpack is ready.

The rain has stopped, but it rained all night and all morning. The ground is wet, the air is heavy, and I should already be on my way to the bus stop.

Except I can't leave. Not yet.

Cesare isn't answering my message, and I can't leave without paying for the accommodation.

That's the perfectly absurd part.

After four days in which I'd been given an apartment before anyone knew my name, discounts on meals, scooter trips to beaches, *darling*, *I like you*, and *don't go*, I'm now stuck trying to leave for the most ordinary reason possible: I have to pay. And the man I need to pay is nowhere to be found.

The Cat leaves first. She walks around the Dog with elegance, as though she considers him temporarily installed in a lower-ranking but acceptable position.

The Cow quietly withdraws.

The Dog remains on the carpet.

In this entire scene, I'm the only one still trying to follow logic.

BRO: "The episode can't end without the main character's signature."

I look around the terrace again.

It's full, and yet it feels a little empty. Because the man I'm looking for isn't there.

No Cesare at the entrance. No Cesare at the tables. No Cesare with his cigarette, asking whether I slept well or telling me to stay longer.

He's missing. And his absence makes the place feel, for the first time, like just a place.

I remember something he'd said to me the day before. A sentence that, at the time, had passed among all the others, but now, with my backpack ready and my departure delayed, reveals its weight:

"I got used to see you here. To know you are here."

I got used to seeing you here. To knowing you're here.

Not *don't go*.

Not *stay longer*.

Not *are you happy?*

That's what stays with me. Because it didn't sound like a strategy. It didn't sound like a joke. It didn't sound like an attempt to persuade me. It sounded like a simple truth, spoken without decoration: over the past few days, for him, I had become part of the routine. And today the routine is breaking.

Maybe that's why departures are sometimes strange. Not because great stories are ending, but because the small gestures that, without asking anyone, have become habits are ending.

I think about the money.

On the first day, Cesare had said 1,000 a night. I'd negotiated it down to 900. Three nights had become four. Four nights at 900 comes to 3,600.

But now, sitting on this terrace, beside the Dog on the carpet, beside the books labelled *Caesar*, *India*, and *Shaolin*, beside the walls painted by tourists and the flowers wet from the rain, 3,600 seems

too little. Not for the apartment. The apartment had been good, but that wasn't what this was about anymore. I wasn't just paying for the room – I was paying for the chapter.

I remember the beaches he'd taken me to even though, theoretically, he had something to buy. You can't put a price on all of that, obviously, but if there has to be an amount, it might as well close things properly.

MAYA: "I'm thinking of giving him 1,000 a night, what he originally asked for. If he doesn't show up in half an hour, I'll pay the guys by UPI and leave."

BRO: "Elegant. After all that negotiating, Cesare ends up exactly where he started."

MAYA: "At 1,000."

BRO: "The man earned his thousand."

I laugh.

Yes. The man earned his thousand. I don't know if he earned it by Booking standards, but by literary standards, definitely.

I ask one of the guys where Cesare is.

The guy answers calmly:

"Boss is sleeping."

I look at him.

Of course. Naturally.

How else could the Cesare chapter end?

Not *he'll be here in a minute*.

Not *he's gone out*.

Boss is sleeping. The final obstacle between me and leaving is his sleep.

BRO: "That is the most Goa line possible."

MAYA: "Boss is sleeping."

BRO: "Chapter title."

I go to the bathroom.

Because if I can't leave yet, I might as well be logistically prepared when I do.

When I come out, Cesare is awake.

Of course.

That's how Palolem works: you go to the bathroom, come back, and reality has changed the frame.

He's there. A little sleepy, a little dishevelled, with the energy of a man pulled out of a nap that probably had no idea it was part of a narrative structure.

I tell him I need to pay. I make the payment by UPI and show him the amount: 4,000. He says nothing. No reverse negotiation, no *but we agreed on* 900, no *why* 4000?, no drama. He looks at the amount, nods, and that's it.

After all my calculations, after all my theories about 900, 1,000, FIE, the chapter, symmetry, Cesare accepts the payment with the same simplicity with which, on the first day, he accepted my existence in his apartment.

Then he says one of his guys will take me to the bus stop.

I won't have to walk twenty-five minutes through the damp with my backpack on. His guy will take me. To the bus stop.

Right to the end, Cesare remains Cesare: practical, helpful, present in his own way.

He doesn't stop me, doesn't make a scene, doesn't go back to *stay more*, doesn't officially hope for another downpour, doesn't try one last *one more day*.

He only asks:

"You leave?"

That's all.

The answer was already known to the entire cast: the Cow knew, the Dog knew, the Cat had left, Bro knew, I knew. The chapter just needed its final line.

I get onto the scooter of the man Cesare has sent.

Cesare blows me kisses.

That's all: no speech, no *don't go*, no *are you happy*?, no *call me in October*, although October probably remains somewhere in the air, like a room reserved by a possibility.

Just kisses blown through the air.

And, in a way, it's more beautiful like this. Because he doesn't try to change the ending. He accepts it.

BRO: "That's exactly how it had to end."

Yes.

That's exactly how it had to end.

When I arrived in Palolem, I had nowhere to stay. I had my backpack on my back, the heat inside me, exhaustion down to my bones, and the feeling that Goa had left me on the wrong side of the story.

Now I have a book that already exists, an impossible character, a Boss Cow, a FIE Dog, an administrator Cat, a cover in progress, and hundreds of laughs.

I'm not leaving an apartment – I'm leaving an ecosystem.

A four-day routine in which Maya appeared, Cesare asked how she'd slept, the Cow checked the situation, and Bro turned everything into literary evidence. And perhaps that's precisely why it isn't sad – it's complete.

Cesare's guy drops me at the bus stop.

I get on the bus. The road opens up. All I know is that I'm heading towards Margao. Beyond that, not yet.

I look out of the window. I'm no longer at Cesare's, no longer under the Cow's supervision, the red carpet is behind me, and I smile: the Cesare chapter has been handed in.

The next character is probably already arranging their entrance.

Fie.

10
The Last Room

I wasn't completely out of Palolem yet, and Goa was already moving the pieces around.

Cesare had blown me kisses. The Cow had approved my departure from the red carpet. The Dog had remained at his post, looking every inch the FIE official. I was back on the road, my backpack beside me, with the feeling that I'd just handed an entire chapter over to a yellow café in South Goa.

I arrive in Margao and, in less than five minutes, I'm already on my way to Panaji. Someone had worked out the route for me. I'm not exactly sure how. That was the beautiful and slightly suspicious part: I was still getting ready to make decisions, while Goa seemed to have made them already.

Fine.

Panaji, then.

I arrive there in the afternoon, with the exhaustion still clinging to me and the memory of Palolem too fresh for me to enter a new city cleanly. I still had nowhere to sleep and nothing resembling a plan. All I had was my backpack, my phone, a vague list of options, and a tired but still functioning confidence that, eventually, something would come together.

I go into Casanoni Trattoria and order a coffee that is too expensive for my level of clarity. I'd actually wanted pizza, but after

studying the menu, I realise that pizza here seems more like a museum piece than dinner.

I look at the other pizzerias in the area too. More or less the same story: they're all above the budget I want to allocate to an afternoon in which I still don't even have accommodation.

So I decide to walk to Pizza Hut. Not because it has any symbolic value, but because I know I can get pizza there at a price that won't force me to reconsider my financial future. Besides, it exists on the map, it's recognisable, and at that moment it offers me both food and direction.

I tell myself that if I find somewhere along the way, I'll go in and ask.

At the first place where I ask about accommodation, two people look at me as though what has just walked through the door isn't a woman with a backpack but an administrative complication.

That exact look: a mixture of fear, embarrassment, and the hope that the situation will resolve itself if you don't move too much.

"Full, madam."

Of course.

Full madam.

I leave laughing.

The second place begins with a set of steps. An old man is sitting there, deeply absorbed in some inner activity I don't dare interrupt. So I wait quietly. Sometimes check-in begins only after the person has finished whatever they needed to finish with themselves.

After a while, he looks at me.

"Yes. I saw you walk past. I waved at you, but you didn't look."

I laugh.

I'd only been walking around the building, trying to find the entrance. So once again, someone had seen me before I saw them.

We go upstairs.

The first room is nice. Not spectacular, not the kind of place you walk into and say, *This is where I rewrite my destiny*, but it has hot

water and a big bed. In my mind, hot water and a big bed were two almost philosophical arguments.

The second room is awful.

I want the first one.

"Two thousand," he says.

I look at the room.

I look at him.

In my mind, I look at Cesare's apartment, with its living room, kitchen, and three bedrooms.

"I'm alone", I tell him. "It was cheaper online."

He offers me the other room for 1,500.

The awful room.

Or the first room for 3,500 for two nights.

That was where my internal conversation ended. I wasn't going to pay 3,500 for two nights when I'd just spent four nights in Cesare's palace for 4,000, and that price had included the Cow, the beaches, and an official Dog.

I leave.

Things that don't work out don't disappear – they just push you onto another street.

I get to Pizza Hut.

I need to go to the bathroom, but the bathroom isn't working. Normally, a bathroom that isn't working is a problem. In the logic of the past few days, it's often the beginning of a scene.

At that exact moment, the rain starts hammering down outside.

It isn't raining nicely, it isn't drizzling poetically – it's hammering down with determination, as though someone has turned the volume all the way up at the exact moment I need a door with TOILET written on it.

The girl at Pizza Hut looks at me and points out of the window.

"Go there."

She points to a petrol station not far away. I can see it.

In theory, the solution is only a few dozen metres away. In practice, between me and the solution is a curtain of water that seems to be saying: *Go on, cross.*

The girl says:

"I give you my umbrella."

I look at her, I look at the rain, and still decide to hold it until I've finished my pizza and the rain stops.

The girl smiles at me as though she's just said: *You can cross the monsoon with a stranger's umbrella, or you can cross nothing at all.*

I order a pizza and stay there.

I move to the back, by the window. From there, I can see the rain better. Through the window, I see a huge ship, Titanic-style, anchored across the road, in the harbour or whatever it was over there. An enormous white ship, absurdly beautiful in that rain, appearing right in my Pizza Hut frame while I negotiate with my bladder, accommodation, and the immediate future.

I'm sitting in a Pizza Hut in Panaji, with a bathroom that doesn't work, rain against the window, and a local Titanic across the road.

Of course.

Why not?

BRO: "In your case, things that don't work turn into cinematic scenery first."

He's right.

If the bathroom had been working, maybe I would have left before I saw the ship. If the first place hadn't been full, if the old man hadn't asked for 3,500, if the rain hadn't started at that exact moment, maybe I wouldn't have ended up sitting in a Pizza Hut in Panaji, looking for accommodation, with a local Titanic across the road.

So that's what I do: I sit, I eat, I wait for the rain to stop, and I search.

Nothing interesting.

And then a hostel appears on Booking: White Hostel. 1,470 rupees for two nights. It says it's the last room. Or the last possibility Booking still had up its sleeve.

Perfect.

After Palolem, the words *last room* no longer scare me – they interest me.

I book it.

When the rain stops, I set off on foot. Ten minutes, according to the map.

The little streets are full of people in colourful raincoats. Wet asphalt, old walls, soft light, my flip-flops already resigned to the idea that Goa means mud, water, and decisions made between two downpours.

I roll up my trousers and follow the GPS. Naturally, the GPS doesn't take me where I need to go. That would have been too simple and, after everything that had happened, almost suspicious.

I reach a point where the map insists the hostel should be there, while reality calmly disagrees.

I ask two women. Then a man.

I get directions, gestures, explanations.

Eventually, I find the hostel on a narrow street that wasn't visible from the main road. Aha. So it was hiding. Of course. After the past few days, I was beginning to understand that some accommodation likes to lie in wait for a while, just to see whether you deserve the scene.

I go in.

The girls at reception already know my name from Booking.

After Cesare, who had given me an entire apartment before he even knew what I was called, this feels almost shockingly administrative.

"Maya?"

Yes.

Maya.

Look how simple things can be when the system works.

The girls tell me breakfast is included.

After four nights in Cesare's impossible apartment, my mind no longer has normal criteria. Everything gets compared with Cesare and loses, but White Hostel has a quiet elegance that makes me lower my guard.

Then comes the room.

There are several beds, but no one else. For now, the girl says. There's a 99% chance I'll have the room to myself.

I look at the three empty beds and laugh. Panaji had started well.

Palolem: I can't find anything, I get an entire apartment.

Panaji: I book the last room and end up almost alone in it.

I'm not booking accommodation anymore – I seem to be challenging probability.

Later, I go out into the beautiful hall and sit down to write. The hall has something colonial about it – airy, beautiful, with a quietness nothing like Cesare's terrace. There, everything was colourful, full, bovine, warm, slightly chaotic. Here, it's different: wood, high walls, space, cool air, an order that doesn't embrace me but welcomes me.

The girls turn on the air conditioning for me, make me a latte in a little glass cup, and I settle in comfortably and open my laptop.

BRO: "This can't be normal accommodation."

MAYA: "It's fairly normal."

BRO: "You have an almost private room, breakfast included, and a latte in a little glass cup. After Palolem, this is called assisted transition."

I laugh.

Maybe this was exactly what I needed.

Not another Cesare, not another Boss Cow, not another teacher from Mumbai kissing me with cosmic arguments. I'd been given a beautiful hall, a hot latte, air conditioning, and a few hours to process everything that had happened.

Of course, the peace doesn't last long, because I make the mistake of joking.

MAYA: "If anyone turns up today, I just hope he's tall, slim, dark-haired, and has a certain something."

BRO: "I see that, only a few hours after officially parting ways with Cesare, the selection criteria are already in place."

I laugh.

It's just a joke.

Or, well, in Goa, jokes need to be made with caution. They have a tendency to materialise partially, incorrectly, or with suspicious timing.

It isn't long before reality runs a technical rehearsal.

Dark-haired, yes.

As for the other criteria, Goa was in no hurry.

He doesn't say anything, just walks past me in the hall. Then he walks past again. And again.

I sit there with my latte, my laptop, and a recent experience that has taught me not to take people seriously until their third appearance. He's already reached ten.

MAYA: "He walked past again."

BRO: "Field report. Panaji. Beautiful hall. Latte. Maya at her post. Current situation: the man walked past."

MAYA: "We know nothing about him."

BRO: "Name: *no*. Nationality: *no*. Age: *no*. Speaks: *probably, but not to you*. Exists: *yes*. Walks past: *excessively*."

I watch him discreetly.

Or I think I do. In reality, I probably look like a woman who has just emerged from a chapter with cows and is trying not to overinterpret a man walking down a corridor.

He'd walked past too many times for me not to notice him.

Too few for me to know anything.

Panaji, apparently, didn't need the Cow for its first evening. It had a hall and a man who didn't say hello to me.

He walks past again.

I half-close my laptop and watch him go. All I knew was that I'd left Palolem with a chapter closed, arrived in Panaji at the last room and, before I'd even had a chance to catch my breath, the Man Who Walked Past had already appeared.

And Goa, once again, said nothing – it just showed me the corridor.

11

Hakuna Matata

Morning in Panaji comes with rain.

A lot of rain. The kind of rain that doesn't fall but occupies the city: roofs, car wheels, clothes, thoughts. It had been raining all night, and it was still raining.

At half past four in the morning, I'm not asleep.

One minute I'm hot, the next I'm cold. The air conditioning seems to have a personal relationship with my body. I turn it off, it's too hot; I turn it on, it gets too cold.

Meanwhile, somewhere nearby, a dog is barking with ambition. Outside, the water gets on with its business. Inside, I negotiate with the temperature, the sheet, sleep, and my own decision to stay in a hostel after promising myself in Sri Lanka that I wouldn't stay in hostels anymore.

The Man Who Walked Past was, in fact, my roommate.

Except he hadn't appeared all night.

In the absence of information, I give him a name. Then another one: the Dark-Haired Man from the Corridor, the Phantom of the Opera.

I'd seen him in the evening: he'd had a shower, dressed nicely, put on some cologne, put on his trainers, and disappeared into the night, without a word, without a glance, without confirming that he belonged to the same conversational species as me.

He returns at 6:56.

He comes into the room – not particularly loudly, but not quietly enough for me not to hear him either – turns on the air conditioning, moves around for a while, and gets into bed.

Where had he been? I don't know. And it was none of my business.

But, being me, of course my mind noted the time, the footsteps, the air conditioning, the disappearance, the reappearance, and the complete mystery of a man who doesn't say hello but has a nightlife.

At 9:30, the alarm goes off. My eyes feel gritty. I hear the rain and the hum of the air conditioning. Every now and then, I hear him too. He goes out, comes back in.

When I get up to go to the bathroom, he's in bed. When I come out of the bathroom, he's disappeared. Instead of an opera, we have White Hostel, rain, bunk beds, and a man who seems to have a strained relationship with saying hello.

I go out and tell the girl at reception that I'd like breakfast too.

I wait patiently.

MAYA: "The Phantom of the Opera has appeared."

BRO: "At 6:56. Very precise for a phantom."

MAYA: "He still doesn't say hello."

BRO: "He has a schedule, not dialogue."

He's right.

After Palolem, where everyone talked, invited, kissed, offered things, and occupied the red carpet, Panaji begins with people who walk past, disappear, and say nothing.

Different film.

I'm right next to reception, at a small round table, waiting for the omelette and coffee included in the price. There's something deeply reassuring about breakfast being included after days in which everything was negotiated, offered, discounted, given away for free, or paid extra for literary reasons.

The curly-haired woman I saw yesterday is there too. She's eating. She has a newspaper and a book in front of her. She looks up and

smiles at me. Today, we recognise each other and that's all, because in a hostel, recognition counts as a social relationship.

I sit there, still sleepy, my mind barely connected to the day.

My eyes, however, are working. That's what they do even when the body doesn't want to: they register things.

A nice guy appears.

Very nice, actually.

He says hello, laughs, talks easily, and sits down at the desk behind reception. From the way he moves, the way the others respond to him, the calm of a man who doesn't need permission to be there, he seems to be the boss.

Aha.

Without meaning to, I put him in the file.

I don't yet know that later that evening, I'll spend more than an hour talking to him. Right now, he's just an interesting character who has appeared on a rainy morning in Panaji.

An old man appears too, white-haired and slightly stooped, and talks to him at length.

Then I hear him talking to the curly-haired woman about a beach. About how he can take her there. Or arrange something for her. I don't hear everything. I hear fragments: a beach, a journey, the rain, maybe later.

I'm not in their story, but I'm sitting beside it.

And I realise I like that. If I'm not the main character in the scene, I notice other people's characters.

BRO: "You don't have to take up the whole screen to be the main character."

I don't answer – it's too early for clever sentences.

I need coffee.

The Phantom of the Opera appears at reception too. He says something brief. Very brief. Probably functional.

Then he leaves.

So he can talk – just not to me.

When I go back to the room, I find him sprawled on the bench where I'd sat writing the night before. He's scrolling through his phone.

I walk past him without paying any attention to him. Exactly as he did yesterday. My little acts of revenge are discreet but satisfying.

I go to the bathroom, then get back into bed after turning off the air conditioning and opening the window wide. It's nice. I can hear the rain, and I want to work. Especially since I've already received the email with the CIP data for *Love Me, But Don't Possess Me*.

I'm pleased, but the internet is horrible. Not weak or temperamental, but horrible. The kind of internet that makes you understand that civilisation is only an optimistic assumption.

Meanwhile, the Phantom comes in and turns on the air conditioning.

Then he goes out.

Comes back in.

Eventually, he gets into bed.

I get up, close the window, then draw the curtain around my bed and that's it – I go to sleep too. I sleep until four in the afternoon.

When I wake up, I'm hungry.

It's still raining outside. Of course. Panaji seems determined to offer me the city in water form.

I put on my pink raincoat and go out.

I walk about five hundred metres to a shop. I go in and buy a croissant. Just as I'm about to pay, I realise I don't have my phone. I stop, look in my bag, rummage through it – nothing.

Pfff. I left it on the bed.

I walk back through the light rain to get it, wearing my pink raincoat and feeling that sometimes life doesn't give you characters – it just sends you back for your phone. I get to the room, grab it, and go out again.

This time, I go straight to buy cherries. I'd seen them earlier. Cherries in Panaji, in the rain. 500 rupees a kilo. Expensive, but I

was craving them so badly that it didn't matter anymore. I buy half a kilo and hold them like a personal victory. After so many days of rice, noodles, lassi, pizza, and hummus, the cherries feel like a simple, perfect luxury.

Then I go straight to Pizza Hut.

I don't feel like trying any local restaurant. I want something familiar, predictable, with a table, a chair, and, if possible, no existential revelation between slices.

I go in.

Two tables are occupied.

The girl from yesterday is there. She smiles at me.

"Same pizza?"

I laugh.

She remembers me.

Then she adds:

"Now, if you need the bathroom, it's fixed."

Seriously?

Brilliant.

After just one day, the girl at Pizza Hut knows my order and the history of my bladder. This is already a small-town relationship.

I order and sit at the same table as yesterday so I can see the Titanic through the window.

Before I eat, I wash the cherries in the bathroom. The repaired bathroom. A small infrastructural miracle.

When she brings me my glass of 7UP, I ask if she wants some cherries.

She says no.

Then I tell her it's too hot and ask her to turn on the air conditioning. She tells me it doesn't work in that part, but I can move to the other side. It only works there.

I move and, as I do, I realise something: the girl is alone.

"Are you here on your own?"

I just want to make sure I've understood correctly.

"Yes."

And she laughs.

I look at her. How do you run a franchise on your own?

A girl of about twenty-five, maybe five feet tall, alone in a Pizza Hut in Panaji, in the rain, with occupied tables, orders, drinks, and customers who want air conditioning and cherries on the table.

Meanwhile, three more tables fill up. As I eat, I seriously consider getting up to help her. At least clear some tables, carry a glass, do something.

But I don't.

I sit there, eat pizza, eat cherries, drink 7UP, and observe.

I notice the couple at one of the tables, who look newly married. The woman has traces of red henna on her hands and feet. After so many days, I knew how to read at least that much. She gives him her glass to drink from, and he takes out her straw, puts his own in, and only then takes a sip. A small gesture. Almost invisible. The kind of gesture that says more than a grand declaration.

I notice two guys who seem annoyed that the girl isn't moving faster with their order.

I notice the rain beating against the window.

A place a tourist might sheepishly put in the category of *I had no inspiration, so I ate at Pizza Hut* becomes, for me, a little theatre with partially functioning air conditioning.

It's only when I get up that I see a guy has appeared and is helping her.

Good. Reinforcements had arrived. I can leave without signing up as a volunteer.

I'd thought about going for a walk, but it's still raining outside. This city has brought me a lot of water, I notice. I put on my pink raincoat and head straight back to White Hostel.

At the entrance, on a little white bench, I see the guy from this morning. The nice-looking one, with the air of a boss without making a big deal of it.

I hadn't been wrong. He really was the boss.

His name is Fahad.

I take off my pink raincoat, and he invites me to sit down. He asks if I'd like something to drink and asks the girls at reception to make me a coffee.

"Did you go out to eat or to see the city?"

I laugh.

"I went to Pizza Hut, had a pizza, and came back. It's not really sightseeing weather today."

"So you have fifty restaurants around you and you go to Pizza Hut?"

"Yes. What can I say? Sometimes I do that."

We laugh.

I tell him that line will probably end up in the book I'm writing. He looks amused, without seeming completely surprised.

He tells me he'd wanted to talk to me since the morning.

"Yes," I say. "But you were busy with the curly-haired woman."

I say it too quickly, perhaps.

Or too precisely.

He looks at me for a second, as though checking whether I'd simply noticed or noticed too much.

"She is an architect," he says. "Famous. Very intelligent."

"Yes, I noticed her too. I really like her. She's very beautiful. I like her features."

He looks at me strangely.

So I add, pre-emptively:

"Don't worry," I tell him, laughing. "I'm not flirting with her."

He makes a small gesture, difficult to translate but expressive enough.

Something between relief, amusement, and *good to know*.

Aha. Panaji had started talking more quietly than Palolem, but that didn't mean it wasn't saying anything.

Then we get onto travel. We talk about Indonesia, and he tells me he speaks eight languages, including Indonesian. I raise my eyebrows. Eight languages.

Fine. Panaji had changed register: no more Cesare-FIE; now we had Fahad the polyglot.

I stay there with him at the entrance, in a white-painted corridor, and we get talking. For more than an hour. Maybe longer.

The rain continues to hold the city in a kind of parenthesis, and we sit there, facing each other, talking as though that was exactly what the rainy afternoon had been invented for.

He's 41 and tells me, laughing, that he was born on 9/09 at nine in the morning – a detail so symmetrical I almost don't trust it.

"Nine is a magic number."

"I know."

I learn that he's divorced and loves exploring new worlds and cultures.

I learn about Kalimantan, about a two-year work visa, and about an import-export business involving some volcanic material whose name I immediately forget. I retain only the idea: volcano, Indonesia, trade, eight languages, hostel, rain.

He stays in one place and lets the world come to him.

I do the opposite: I go towards people like him.

He asks me how I choose places.

I laugh.

"Most of the time, I don't choose them. They let themselves be chosen."

I tell him I hadn't wanted to come to Panaji.

I'd actually wanted to get to Anjuna. But the bus passed through here, I looked at the map and thought: why not? I'll stay here for two days as well.

Simple. No grand plans.

I might never have ended up at his hostel at all.

And yet yesterday, in a Pizza Hut in Panaji, after a bathroom that didn't work, torrential rain, and a Titanic through the window, I'd broken my own rule and booked White Hostel.

I don't know if that means anything. Not in that grand sense where every detour has to be a sign. But I do know I could have stopped earlier. I could have stayed with the old man who wanted 3,500 for two nights. I could have insisted on Anjuna.

But I didn't. I went a little further.

Maybe my intuition doesn't always tell me where to go. Maybe it just gives me a gentle nudge not to stop yet.

Fahad listens to me.

He's curious. He says he wants to read my writing, but that he'd like to know my story from before I left. So I give him my book about Vietnam – *Days and Nights of Vietnam: The Puzzle of My Soul* – as a gift, in PDF. It's the beginning of my journey with a backpack. It seems fitting – if the man collects stories, he should get a whole one, or at least the beginning of one.

Then he tells me he lives in the house next door and asks if I'd like to see it.

I get up and follow him.

The entrance is right next to the hostel.

It's only when I step inside that I realise: on the other side of the wall I'd been sitting beside the night before, with my latte and laptop in front of me, was his living room. And I'd been joking with Bro that if someone had to appear, he might as well be tall, dark-haired, and have a certain something. The Dark-Haired Man from the Corridor had appeared first, like a badly delivered technical rehearsal.

Fahad was the man who matched the joke.

I'm in no hurry to call it destiny. For now, it's just the discreet architecture of a well-placed joke.

The house has two bedrooms, a living room, a kitchen, and a courtyard at the back. It's beautiful. Big. Spacious. A house that breathes differently from the hostel.

He shows me the bathrooms and says that was where all the work had been, really. I'm not exactly sure what he means. Maybe the renovations, maybe the plumbing, maybe the fact that here, civilisation is sometimes measured by how well the water runs.

He invites me to dinner.

I decline.

I'd only just come back from pizza. And, if I'm being truthful, something in me tells me to keep a little air between myself and any nice-looking man who opens a door too quickly.

"If you want to talk later, you know where to find me," he says.

Yes.

I know.

But no, thanks. At least not now.

He walks me back to the hostel entrance. Reception is already closed, so I make a mental note to pay for the coffee the next day.

I go back into the hall and write.

I'd stay in the room, but there's barely any signal. So I stay in this beautiful hall, where the internet seems slightly more willing to cooperate, and write everything down.

I have to.

Because these days evaporate quickly. In the morning, you think you'll remember; by evening, you already can't quite remember who said what, when it rained, who walked past, who smiled, who showed you their house.

At reception, there's a little sign that says *Hakuna Matata*. I check what it means. In Swahili, it means: *no problem*, *don't worry*.

I laugh.

Because suddenly, it's no longer a decorative sign – it's the administrative summary of the past few weeks.

It doesn't promise that everything will be perfect. It just says: don't panic if the road changes.

Can't find accommodation?

Hakuna Matata.

Can't sleep?

Hakuna Matata.

Pizza Hut's bathroom is broken, and the next day it works?

Hakuna Matata.

Don't know where I'll be tomorrow?

Hakuna Matata.

It isn't forced optimism. It isn't personal development. And I still have some negotiating to do with *the universe gives you what you need*.

Maybe it doesn't give you what you ask for, but what you asked for without knowing it.

It's simpler.

We'll see.

That's it.

We'll see.

MAYA: "Bro, I think I've found the chapter title."

BRO: "So far, no problem has managed to close the chapter."

Yes.

Exactly.

And maybe, finally, I was beginning to understand the joke.

MAYA: "It could be a title, not just a chapter title."

BRO: "That doesn't sound like a joke anymore."

I look at the sign.

Maya, Bro, the Cow and Hakuna Matata. That's how the first version appears. Too long, maybe. Too crowded. The Cow probably doesn't even need to be in the title. The Cow knows anyway.

Something simpler remains, at least for now: *Maya, Bro and Hakuna Matata*.

It has Maya. It has Bro. And it leaves room for everything you ask for without knowing it.

I sit with the title in front of me for a while, the rain beyond the windows. On the screen, Hakuna Matata works perfectly. By evening, the room begins to test its limits.

I have a shower, wash my hair, and get into bed. While I'd been sitting in the hall, another guy had arrived in the room. So now there were three of us. It wasn't a tragedy yet. Just confirmation that Booking, like life, uses the word *last* very loosely.

I want to write some more, but the internet doesn't work from the bed. I go back out into the hall and write there for a while.

This hall is turning into my temporary office. White Hostel, with its sign, its people walking past, Fahad at the entrance and the Phantom vanished into the night, is beginning to develop a logic of its own.

It's late when I go back to the room. The new guy is in the top bunk. The Phantom has disappeared again. He has a night schedule. Brilliant.

I get into bed and try to sleep.

This night is even harder. The air conditioning feels as though it's biting into me.

The guy in the top bunk sets it to 28 degrees. Now it's blowing almost warm air, but I still feel as though something is tightening around my throat. I don't know whether it's the air, the exhaustion, the rain, the shared space, or the fact that other people have access to the remote control and, by implication, to my nervous system.

Again, I don't sleep.

I can't. At five in the morning, I'm awake, thinking with dread that I have to leave.

I'm not spending another night in a room where my comfort is decided by communal vote.

Hakuna Matata, yes.

But I want my own room.

12

Hope to Meet U Again

I wake up with difficulty at around 9:20.

It isn't waking up – it's extraction. My body doesn't want to get out of bed, my mind doesn't want to enter the day, and my throat feels as though it was lined with sandpaper overnight.

The Phantom of the Opera – the guy in the room with the night schedule – is stirring. In the bathroom, back in the room, packing his things. He moves around enough to exist, but not enough to become conversation.

Then he goes out to eat.

So do I.

Fahad is at reception, on the little divan by the entrance, with the same old man from yesterday. He seems to have been sitting there since the beginning of time, or at least since I started needing a room of my own.

The old man already seems part of the living furniture of the place: the neighbour who comes over, sits, talks, settles into someone else's day without asking permission, but without disturbing it either.

Fahad sees me.

He doesn't just say hello. He reads me.

"You don't look good."

I laugh, but what comes out is more of a rasp.

My voice is no longer a voice; it's medical evidence.

"I'm not well", I tell him. "I can't even talk."

He looks at me for a few seconds, without panic, without making a show of it.

"Extend your stay. Don't go like this."

And here, for a moment, the sentence *don't go* sounds nothing like Cesare's sentence. There's no hook in it and no possession. Just one person seeing that another person isn't well and telling her not to leave sick, in the rain.

After the past few days, that's almost revolutionary.

I, however, have only one clear desire: a room where no one else can turn on the air conditioning. My room. Not a shared room, not a bed with a curtain, not roommates with access to the remote control. Not even the Phantom of the Opera, who appears at 6:56 and decides the climate.

My room.

I order a cappuccino and porridge. That's all.

The food arrives, but the taste remains somewhere far away from me, probably in a healthier version of the day. I try to eat like a responsible person, even though my body isn't cooperating.

I want to pay for yesterday's coffee too, the one I had outside with Fahad, in the white corridor, when we talked about Indonesia, stories, and places that let themselves be chosen.

Fahad tells me it's on him.

I don't insist. Not because it's a grand gesture, but because right then I no longer have the energy to defend myself against kindness. After days of rain, bad internet, a shared room, and hostile air conditioning, even a cappuccino paid for by someone else takes on disproportionate dimensions.

After the old man leaves, Fahad and I end up talking again.

He tells me, again, not to go. To sleep for a while, to recover before I move on.

"That's what I should do," I tell him.

And it really is what I should do.

I should be the rational person who says: I'm ill, I'm tired, it's raining, I need sleep, I'll stay. But I can't stay in that room anymore.

"But I have to leave. I want a room without air conditioning."

That's when Fahad tells me that the Phantom of the Opera had made a complaint about me. He'd asked to be moved.

The reason?

I'd turned off the air conditioning.

Aha. So that was why the man didn't talk to me. He wasn't mysterious, he wasn't poetic, he wasn't a Gothic character in a rainy hostel in Panaji. The man was annoyed with me.

BRO: "So the Phantom doesn't say hello. The Phantom files complaints."

Exactly.

The Phantom disappeared at night, appeared at 6:56, didn't say hello, didn't make eye contact, but somehow found the administrative resources for climate-related complaints.

Reception had told him they couldn't move him.

Good thing I was finding out now, at least. I wasn't leaving with an incomplete file.

Fahad also tells me that the old man is his neighbour and that he's always dropping by for a chat. That explains everything. White Hostel wasn't just accommodation; it was a place of transit that behaved like a living room: people came, sat down, said something, left something behind, moved on.

The curly-haired woman from yesterday appears too, the one Fahad had told me was an architect. Her name is Srushti, and she's from Pune. Today, I talk to her more, in that slightly hurried way you talk to people when you know you're leaving.

I find out that Fahad has already told her I'm a writer.

She asks if she can see my books. Then I remember I have my book about Bali in my backpack, in Romanian, and I show it to her. She says she'd like to read it in English, so I send her the PDF of the English edition on WhatsApp and give it to her as a gift.

I like the gesture. I'd given Fahad *Vietnam*, the beginning of my life with a backpack. I give Srushti *Bali – Steps Through INDONESIA: When Bali Touches Your Soul* – the next book. My books had started travelling around like little personal passports.

Fahad protests immediately:

"Not fair. I have only Vietnam."

We laugh.

I tell them they can swap books if they want.

Fahad says that wouldn't be fair to me. That amuses me, but touches me a little too.

There's something lovely about our little scene at reception: me, ill and sleep-deprived, my backpack almost ready; Fahad, the man who listens to stories; Srushti, the architect from Pune; the old neighbour already gone; the Phantom somewhere in the hostel, probably still at war with the air conditioning.

We take photos.

Meanwhile, the rain stops. That matters enormously. I can walk to the bus stop without worrying.

Fahad stays on the little white bench, in that spot of his, like a man who knows that some stories don't end when someone puts their backpack on.

I think about heading towards Anjuna.

We'll see what happens at the bus stop.

That's how I leave Panaji: without any grand ceremony, without a conclusion, with an inflamed throat, with a book sent to Fahad and another to Srushti, with the Phantom administratively clarified and White Hostel left behind like a white corridor where, for two days, the rain, the people, and the stories had mingled just enough to become a chapter.

On the way, Fahad messages me.

"Stay in touch. It was a short time but it was nice knowing u."

I look at the message.

A short time. Yes.

White Hostel had been rain, a white hall, bad internet, the Phantom of the Opera, Srushti, breakfast included, the Hakuna Matata sign, and Fahad, sitting there and listening to the stories of people who had come from all over the world.

I reply:

"Yessss, me too."

Then I add:

"Some stories don't have to be long to be unforgettable."

I don't know where the sentence comes from, but I know it's true.

"Yes and ur a person who makes stories and people on the writing really liked it. Keep safe wherever u are."

I stop for a moment.

After so many days of me observing everyone else, someone was telling me, in his own way, that I was worth observing too. That I make stories.

The rest of the message remained slightly crooked, but its warmth came through intact. I don't know exactly what he meant. I don't need to. Sometimes words reach you before you can fully translate them.

I reach the bus station after about twenty minutes.

I find a bus to Mapusa. Apparently, there isn't a direct one to Anjuna. I have to go there first and catch another one from there. Everything happens quickly.

Just like that.

Within three minutes, I'm already on my way. I don't have time to doubt, I don't have time to rethink the plan, I don't have time to convene my internal committee on analysis, fear, options, and budgets.

Panaji hands me over.

So does Mapusa.

A guy shows me the platform where the bus to Anjuna leaves from. I've barely had time to sit down beside my backpack when it appears.

I get on.

A few minutes later, it leaves.

Everything is going too well. Almost suspiciously.

Even my throat seems to ease up a little, simply because I'm no longer paying attention to it.

On the bus, I think about the past few days, about Fahad and the way everything had come one after another, without a pause: lived, written, processed, put into words.

After an hour on the road, I get off in Anjuna with no plan at all.

I'm hungry. The porridge from the hostel and the coffee are long gone, along with my last reserve of administrative energy.

I look for a café on the map. I find one and head towards it.

When I get there, it's closed. Of course.

Anjuna – village, neighbourhood, state of mind, or whatever it is – is full of cows. After Palolem, I can no longer see a cow without assuming she has an official function. One of them is standing in the middle of the road: black, massive, with that hump on her back, blocking almost all of it. She isn't doing anything – just standing there, looking, thinking. Only she knows what about.

I stop in front of her.

"Are you on the welcoming committee?"

No answer.

Of course. The ones in senior positions rarely respond.

A guy on a motorbike sees me looking at the cow and asks what I'm looking for.

"I want a café."

"There are lots around here."

"Yes, but I want a cappuccino."

That's it.

I'm not at a point where I can negotiate with coffee uncertainty.

He tells me there's one a little further away, Anjuna Cafe. I turn back the way he tells me, but I don't make it to his café. I'd seen something closer to the junction where the bus had dropped me off, so I go there instead. And it's a good thing I do: the place is stylish, beautiful, airy.

But there's no one inside. Just the girl behind the bar.

I quickly order a cappuccino, then ask to use the bathroom because I can't wait any longer. Only after that do I look at the menu. The order of priorities is clear: coffee, bathroom, food, existential meaning.

I order a croissant with scrambled egg and Parmesan. Very tasty.

While I'm there, I look for accommodation.

I find about three cheaper options; the rest are already creeping into the territory where my budget starts coughing. I message them, but none of them replies.

Aha. Fine. I'll come to you.

What follows is a small property-viewing procession through Anjuna: a homestay closed for the off-season, a woman who sends me to her brother's resort, a guy who recognises my message but tells me he has no rooms left, and a room for 900 where the mould greets me before the owner does.

No.

No, no.

I can smell it before I even see the room. It's the kind of smell that goes straight into your lungs and says: *I know you. I will destroy you.*

I leave.

At the woman's brother's resort, I call out twice before someone appears from a room at the back. He was sleeping. At midday. Seriously.

The room is decent, but it costs 2,000. The neighbours want 2,000 too without even showing me anything.

I leave again.

I wander off down the street.

I'd seen a resort further along that looked more expensive, but I tell myself: if I'm going to pay 2,000 anyway, I might as well know what I'm paying for. By now, I'm exhausted. The backpack is killing my back, the heat is running beneath my T-shirt. My legs are heavy, my throat

is still bad, and Goa, after keeping me under rain yesterday, is boiling me today between puddles, cows, and closed accommodation.

But I get there.

The resort looks good: spacious entrance, a man in uniform at the gate, cool air inside. They have rooms, but they're 2,700 a night.

What? I tell the guy at reception that Google says 2,144.

He takes my phone, taps around for a bit, opens one of the apps where they've listed the property, and now it shows me 2,440.

"Book it here," he says.

I look at him.

"Why should I book it there? I'm standing right in front of you."

Then I say:

"Let me see the room anyway. I want to see if it's worth it."

The room is nice.

Big bed. Bathroom with hot water. Toilet paper, even. A nice picture on the wall and a little terrace out front with two chairs. At that moment, all my principles about budgets look at me and fall silent. I decide I'm not running around anywhere else today. This room is good. Maybe I can get the price down a bit. I deserve it after two nights in a hostel.

Not that White Hostel was bad – I liked it – but this feels pretty good too. After two nights with a shared remote control, a little terrace starts to feel like a constitutional right.

We go back to reception and, once again, the negotiations begin, but the man won't budge: he won't go below 2,500, end of story.

Eventually, I say: fine.

I pay.

One night won't kill me. Tomorrow, I'll figure out what to do.

At least today I'm staying at a resort in Anjuna. What can I say?

I go into the room and have a shower to wash the mud off my legs. After all the puddles and wet roads, I was pretty well splattered.

Then I want to go to the sea. Ten minutes, a walk, that's all. I need to buy a bottle of water too; I realise there isn't one in the room.

Strange. Here, almost everyone gives you a bottle of water. But a four-star hotel? No. Of course.

When I go out to look for water, a strong wind starts up. So strong that it turns me back just in time. As soon as I get to the room, the storm breaks: rain and wind.

I sit and work on my laptop for a while. After a good hour or so, the storm dies down.

It's almost six, and I want to at least see the sunset. I put on my green dress, a little too elegant for Anjuna after the rain, and set off on foot through the village. People look at me. Not that they hadn't looked at me before, but now they have one more reason.

The road is challenging: puddles, mud, cows, humid air, half-alive shops, places that seem to be waiting for the season like a return to life.

At the end is the beach. Or rather, a jetty, a kind of stepped area where you can watch the sunset.

Before you get there, there are a few stalls selling all sorts of things.

A woman sees me.

"Come, look. Looking is free."

I smile and stop.

Mistake. Because yes, looking is free, but the avalanche of words isn't. Bracelets. Rings. I should buy something from her because she has no customers, it's the off-season. Buy something. Look. Choose. Don't leave with nothing.

Looking was free. Getting out of the conversation wasn't. I manage to tear myself away.

She calls after me:

"You come back to buy, yes?"

"I'm not promising."

And I carry on.

I take a few photos of the sunset and the sea. When I come back, the woman is still there, but she's busy and doesn't see me. Good.

That's when I understand something. Or maybe it only seems that way that evening, with my body tired, my throat inflamed, and off-season Goa around me: the sea, when it isn't the season, has a sad way of existing.

Not the sea itself – it does what it does.

Comes in, goes out, crashes, breathes.

But everything around it – the jetty, the stalls, the half-empty resorts, the dogs, the cows, the muddy roads – feels like scenery left behind after the show has ended or before it begins.

Goa, famous Goa, seems sad to me.

I'm not saying it as a truth. I'm saying it as a feeling.

On the way back, I buy a bottle of water, a banana, and a mango and return to my room. I want to read the new book one more time before I send it to print. So I spend a long time in bed with my laptop, the file, my dodgy throat, and the increasingly clear feeling that the air isn't going all the way in.

I try to ignore it. I work, read, correct a few more things, and pretend, as much as I can, that it's just exhaustion. But the body doesn't stay fooled for long.

The later it gets, the tighter my breathing becomes. Eventually, I understand: my allergy has flared up.

I'd been thinking of heading towards Arambol. I'd already looked at the route, how to get there, and what accommodation there was. But now, in this room that's too expensive for the state I'm in, with the sea nearby and my body exhausted, I understand that tomorrow I have to move away from the sea.

Otherwise, the allergy will get worse. I already know that.

My phone is beside the pillow.

Outside, the sea is close, but it doesn't calm me.

I message Fahad and tell him I don't like it here very much: a lot of the accommodation is closed, there's been a storm, and Goa, in this part, seems to have pulled its shutters halfway down.

Fahad doesn't insist or turn the conversation into advice. He just tells me there's a lot to explore in the north and asks if I've eaten.

No. I hadn't had dinner.

Then he messages me:

"Always be safe."

I look at the screen.

It's simple, almost banal. But after roads, rain, closed accommodation, changing buses, cows in the middle of the road, mouldy rooms, expensive hotels, exhaustion, and people who appear only to leave, *be safe* no longer sounds banal – it sounds like a hand resting for a moment on the edge of the story.

I tell him I'll be careful.

Then his message appears on the screen:

"Hope to meet u again."

The Energy U Carry

Epilogue

Two days later, I was no longer in Goa.

I was in Satara, in a city where almost no one spoke English, after a night when, finally, I'd slept well. Goa was behind me now, with its rain, its cows, Panaji, White Hostel, and that white corridor where, for a moment, a few lives had passed close enough to one another to leave traces.

That was when Fahad messaged me.

"How are u? Where are u now?"

"Satara."

His reply came immediately:

"My God."

I laugh.

Yes. Satara.

I didn't really know how I'd ended up there either. Or I did, but not in the way you know a plan. I only knew that the roads had connected, people had helped me, buses had come, someone had shown me something, someone else had told me where to get off, and I had kept going.

I tell him that almost no one speaks English here.

"Yes, mostly Marathi."

Then:

"Wherever unpopular place ur going, let me know. I'll tell u the story about that city."

I look at the message and smile.

Fahad had remained, in his own way, exactly where I'd left him: the man who listens to stories and, if you tell him where you are, gives you one back.

I accept the deal.

After a few messages about roads and cities I hadn't really chosen, he writes:

"Sorry u were not able to be restful at our place here."

I stop for a moment.

White Hostel hadn't been rest. It had been rain, air conditioning, the Phantom of the Opera, bad internet, breakfast included, Hakuna Matata, Srushti, and Fahad in the white corridor.

It hadn't been rest.

But it didn't matter anymore.

I tell him it doesn't matter. It was enough that we'd met.

"Same. Happy to meet u."

That's all.

Sometimes important things don't need long sentences. They settle between two short messages, with mistakes, abbreviations, and enough space for everything that wasn't said to be heard.

Then comes the message that changes the air of the conversation.

"I saw that spark in the morning."

"You mean in my eyes? The spark in my eyes?"

The reply comes quickly:

"No. The energy u had."

I sit there for a moment, phone in my hand.

After so many days of taking note of everyone else – Safi, Surya, Akanksha, the Cow, Cesare, the teacher from Mumbai, the girl from Pizza Hut, Srushti, the Phantom of the Opera – someone was simply writing down what he had seen in me.

"I was really impressed by wat ur doing."

I tell him I've already written about our meeting.

"Really?"

"Yes. So it stays."

Then he asks:

"Wat was ur opinion about me when u met me?"

I smile.

I don't answer straight away. The truth was already in my pages, and some surprises need to be kept whole until they reach the person they were written for.

"You'll read about it."

"My God."

I imagine his reaction and laugh.

"So you'll not say it to me now?"

"I don't want to spoil the surprise."

"I'll wait."

Before I left Goa, I'd told him something else: that maybe, one day, I'd come back with a book that had his name in it too.

"So sweet," he'd replied.

Back then, it had only been a possibility.

Now he was already on the page.

Then, as if he wanted to put things exactly where they belonged, he writes:

"It's not about ur face or ur physique."

A pause.

"It's about the aura or energy u carry."

"Yes, I have something."

"Charismatic and charming."

I don't answer straight away.

Not because I don't know what to say, but because, for a moment, that message closes something I didn't know had remained open.

Maybe until then, I'd thought I was the one looking at the world.

That I observed. That I collected characters.

That I moved from one place to another and saw things others might miss: a man offering someone a seat on a train, a vendor with a blue barrel clearing a path through the carriage, the Cow on the red

carpet, an Italian who became FIE, a girl running a Pizza Hut on her own, a man walking down a corridor ten times without saying a word.

But all that time, the world had been looking at me too.

Not all the time.

Not everyone.

But some people.

Enough.

"I know."

And I really did.

Not as vanity, not as certainty, not as the response of a woman waiting for someone to confirm something for her – but as the quiet recognition of something that, perhaps, the road had known before I did.

But it was one thing for me to know. It was another for him to see it.

Who are you, Fahad?

Not the nice guy with the cigarette in the corner of his mouth, not the man who speaks eight languages and listens to the stories of people who come from all over the world.

Who are you, beyond all that, that you saw the very thing I didn't expect anyone to see?

He had seen me tired, sleep-deprived, with a raspy voice and my body run down. And yet he hadn't talked about my face, my clothes, or the way I looked. He had talked about my aura. About the energy I carry.

That was all I knew.

The rest was still beyond the door.

Later, the conversation drifts towards life, roads, money, courage, strange places, and the way I always end up outside my comfort zone.

I tell him that sometimes I feel as though I live in a different existence, almost a parallel one.

He tells me it's hard to leave your comfort zone and explore like this. That he's impressed by what I do. That his only concern is that the money keeps coming in so I can keep going.

I tell him that strangers help me a lot on the road without asking for much.

It was true.

One man had made room for me on a train. Another had carried my backpack. Someone had shown me the bus stop. Someone had given me free coffee. Someone had given me an apartment before he even knew my name. Someone had remembered my pizza. Someone had told me which bus to take.

Strangers.

Without asking for much, without explaining, without necessarily staying.

Just enough to push the story forward.

"That's really good."

Yes.

It was.

"I think that's the real power."

"True."

I look at the screen again.

Around me, Satara carries on in its own language, with its own noises, its own people who had no obligation to fit into my story.

Goa was already behind me.

Panaji was behind me.

White Hostel was behind me.

But something from that white corridor had made it all the way here, in a message, in a sentence, in an energy recognised by someone who had seen me on a rainy morning, tired, sleep-deprived, but still whole.

I write one last message:

"I'm outside my comfort zone almost every day."

I look at the sentence.

Almost every day.

The little blue barrel I'd followed through the carriage flashes through my mind; me playing the sophisticated lady for Safi; the man on the train after whom Surya had recommended pepper spray; the condom slipped under the door in Gokarna; the teacher from Mumbai and that short *stop* that had drawn a boundary where my body had demanded one before the words came.

Trains, rooms, strangers, roads where sometimes I'd had more trust than information.

Yes. Almost every day.

I put the phone down.

A few moments later, the screen lights up again.

"Plz be safe ur making me worried always take care."

Continue the Journey

For readers who wish to keep walking alongside Yda and Maya, here are the stories that came before – and those still unfolding. Each journey begins in a different place, but all of them lead inward, towards discovery, change, and the quiet courage of becoming.

1. Days and Nights of Vietnam: The Puzzle of My Soul

Vietnam • 2025

A journey without a return date – not because you don't come back, but because you never return the same. Through vibrant cities, quiet villages, and unexpected encounters, Yda pieces together fragments of herself in a country that slowly becomes a mirror of her inner world.

2. Steps Through Indonesia: When Bali Touches Your Soul

Bali, Indonesia • 2025

This is not a book about Bali as a destination. It is about what shifts inside you when you finally arrive where you dreamed of – and peace still doesn't come. A poetic exploration of vulnerability, transformation, and the quiet awakening that begins when you least expect it.

3. Steps Through Indonesia: In the Hands of Strangers

Java, Indonesia • 2026

A journey without a compass, but filled with meaning. Through volcanic landscapes, train stations, unexpected friendships, and moments of quiet

revelation, Yda discovers that sometimes the most meaningful paths are guided by strangers.

4. Maya, Bro & Hakuna Matata

India • 2026

A journey in search of coffee, rooms, buses, and the occasional answer – only to find stories instead. Between wrong turns, unexpected encounters, a sarcastic inner voice, and cows who seem to know more than they let on, Maya discovers that sometimes the best stories begin when life refuses to follow the plan.

Coming Soon

5. Days and Nights of Vietnam: The Missing Pieces

Vietnam • 2026

Some countries must be visited twice. Not because the places have changed – but because you have. Returning to Vietnam, Yda continues her journey, discovering that what once felt incomplete may finally begin to make sense.

DISCOVER ALL BOOKS BY MIDA MALENA AT

WWW.MIDAWAY.RO/CARTI

How to find characters even without a sun lounger.

— Mida Malena



MIDAWAY